

GrowMailers Master Blueprint

Ideal Customer Profile, Market Sizing, Deliverability Framework and Go-To-Market Plan for Shopify DTC Brands

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How to use this document. Every section opens with a bottom line. Read those alone and you have the strategy in ten minutes. Underneath are the tables, diagrams and SOPs the team works from day to day. Figures come from named public sources current to September 2026, including the US Census Bureau, Store Leads, Klaviyo, Omnisend, Validity, Triple Whale, Google and company filings. Where a number is our own estimate or a planning assumption, we say so. The legal sections are research, not legal advice.

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1. Executive Summary & Strategic Intent

Bottom line: A DTC brand now barely breaks even, or loses money, on the first order it buys with paid media. Its profit comes from the second, third and fourth orders, and email and SMS are the cheapest way to produce them. GrowMailers sells into that gap with two offers. **Ascent** is a USD 5,000 one-time project that fixes the plumbing: authentication, list hygiene and inbox repair. **Lhotse** is a USD 3,000 to 5,500 monthly retainer that runs the whole retention program. The ideal client runs Shopify or Shopify Plus with Klaviyo and sells a repeat-purchase product. Lhotse targets brands turning over USD 3M to 20M a year. Ascent targets USD 1M to 50M+.

1.1 The business thesis

Three pressures are hitting DTC brands at once. **Acquisition costs more every year.** Meta's average price per ad rose 12% year on year in Q2 2026, and it has risen by 6% to 14% every quarter since Q2 2024. **Each order costs more to fulfil.** Tariffs, the end of duty-free entry for low-value parcels into the US and higher freight all eat into margin. About four in five brands told ShipBob that the 2025 tariff changes raised their costs. **The inbox has become stricter.** Gmail, Yahoo and Microsoft now require authentication, one-click unsubscribe and low complaint rates from bulk senders, and they reject mail that fails. Every brand in our ICP sends enough volume to count as a bulk sender.

The result is that retention is where DTC profit comes from. A repeat order driven by email costs cents. A new customer bought through paid media costs 38% to 63% of the first order's value in ad spend, depending on category. Yet most USD 3M to 20M brands still run the email program they set up years ago. Their flows are thin, campaigns go to the whole list, and they pay Klaviyo every month to store dormant and bot profiles. Nobody has checked their authentication since it was first set up. GrowMailers exists to close that gap.

1.2 The two offers

	Ascent	Lhotse
Format	One-time technical project	Monthly managed retainer
Price	USD 5,000	USD 3,000 to 5,500 a month (USD 36,000 to 66,000 a year)
Scope	SPF, DKIM and DMARC; branded sending domain and alignment; list cleaning and suppression; bot defences; sunset policy; inbox repair; warm-up plan	Email and SMS strategy; flow architecture; campaign calendar and execution; segmentation; design and copy; CRO of forms and landing pages; reporting; ongoing hygiene
Delivery	2 to 3 weeks of repair, plus up to 10 weeks of monitored warm-up if a new domain is needed	Ongoing, after 2 to 3 weeks of onboarding
Revenue target	USD 1M to 50M+	USD 3M to 20M
Buying trigger	Bounces, spam placement, "via klaviyomail.com", a Black Friday scare, a rising Klaviyo bill	Flat email revenue, a lost email manager, a disappointing agency, new growth targets
Success measures	Aligned DMARC pass; Gmail spam rate below 0.1%; bounces below 1%; placement restored at weak providers; fewer billed profiles	Email share of website revenue; revenue per recipient; holdout-tested incremental revenue; margin protected through discount discipline

Ascent is a repair project with a clear end, and it is the natural way into a new account. It suits brands that can see the symptoms but cannot diagnose them. It also suits enterprise brands whose CRM teams need a specialist to rebuild authentication or move sending domains without interrupting revenue, a zero-downtime repair (Section 13.8).

We recommend banding Lhotse's price by scope:

Suggested band	Monthly fee	Typical brand	Scope
Lhotse Core	USD 3,000 to 3,500	USD 3M to 6M, email-led	Full flow build and upkeep; 2 to 3 segmented campaigns a week; monthly reporting; hygiene
Lhotse Growth	USD 3,500 to 4,500	USD 6M to 12M, email and SMS	Core, plus a managed SMS program, a structured test plan, replenishment and subscription flows, and quarterly holdout tests
Lhotse Scale	USD 4,500 to 5,500	USD 12M to 20M, multi-market	Growth, plus CRO sprints, predictive segmentation, multi-country calendars and a weekly strategist call

A suggested structure for GrowMailers to confirm against its actual packaging.

EXTERNAL AUDIT → ASCENT PROJECT → 30-DAY RESULTS REVIEW → LHOTSE PROPOSAL
 (free, 15 min) (USD 5,000) (proof in their own data) (USD 3,000–5,500/mo)
 └─ Lhotse-first path when the brand is USD 3M–20M and its technical base is sound ─┘

Lead with Ascent when the audit finds technical debt, since nobody should scale campaigns on a broken sending setup. Lead with Lhotse when the technical base is sound and the gap is in strategy and execution. We also recommend crediting part of the Ascent fee against the first Lhotse month for brands that convert within 60 days. That turns Ascent into a paid trial.

1.3 Financial positioning

Against an in-house hire. Glassdoor puts a US Email Marketing Manager at USD 66,000 to 107,000 base pay. That is roughly USD 85,000 to 135,000 fully loaded (our estimate, assuming 25% to 30% on-costs), for one person with one skill set, a ramp-up period and a single point of failure. Lhotse costs USD 36,000 to 66,000 a year and brings a strategist, designer, copywriter and deliverability specialist from day one.

Against email revenue. Healthy brands earn 20% to 30% of website revenue from email and SMS:

Brand revenue	Email revenue at 20% to 30%	Lhotse as share of email revenue	Verdict
USD 1.5M	USD 300k to 450k	8% to 22%	Too heavy. Sell Ascent.
USD 3M	USD 600k to 900k	4% to 11%	Works
USD 5M	USD 1.0M to 1.5M	2.4% to 6.6%	Comfortable
USD 10M	USD 2.0M to 3.0M	1.2% to 3.3%	Sweet spot
USD 20M	USD 4.0M to 6.0M	0.6% to 1.7%	Easy to justify

Ascent against an incident. A USD 5M brand earning USD 1M a year from email makes about USD 19,000 a week from the channel. If a reputation problem pushes a quarter of its mail into spam, it loses around USD 4,800 a week in an ordinary month (our estimate), and much more in Black Friday week. Ascent pays for itself in one to two weeks of restored placement.

1.4 The fundamental DTC margin gap

A median apparel order, using Triple Whale's category medians and FIGS' reported cost structure:

FIRST ORDER (bought with paid media)			REPEAT ORDER (driven by email)		
Order value	USD	103.37	Order value	USD	103.37
- Product cost (33.5%)	-USD	34.63	- Product cost (33.5%)	-USD	34.63
- Selling costs (23.1%)	-USD	23.88	- Selling costs (23.1%)	-USD	23.88
= Before acquisition	USD	44.86	= Before acquisition	USD	44.86
- Ad cost per purchase	-USD	39.24	- Email/SMS cost	≈-USD	0.10
LEFT BEFORE OVERHEAD	≈ USD	5.62	LEFT BEFORE OVERHEAD	≈ USD	44.76

The first order buys the customer, and the second earns the profit. Here a repeat order is worth about eight times a first order, and the gap widens every year that ad costs rise. We are not selling "better emails". We are selling a bigger share of orders that come with no acquisition cost.

1.5 What this blueprint commits GrowMailers to

- 1. Sell only to brands that own their list.** The minimum stack is Shopify or Shopify Plus with Klaviyo. The brand must own its products and sell mainly through its own site.
- 2. Pick the lead offer from evidence.** Ascent when an outside audit finds technical debt. Lhotse when the brand is USD 3M to 20M and its program is underbuilt.
- 3. Focus on four verticals.** Beauty and personal care, health and supplements, food and beverage, and pet supplies.
- 4. Sell by the calendar.** Never pitch a new retainer into the pre-Black Friday freeze.
- 5. Prove value with holdout tests,** not platform-attributed revenue alone.
- 6. Keep GrowMailers' own sending clean.** A deliverability agency on a blocklist has no credibility.

2. E-Commerce & Direct-to-Consumer (DTC) Taxonomies

Bottom line: Whether a brand owns its customer list decides fit, and revenue comes second. A USD 30M Amazon seller is a worse prospect than a USD 4M Shopify brand, because it cannot email most of its buyers. Dropshippers and print-on-demand stores are excluded as well. They technically hold a list, but they lack the margin, product control and staying power to benefit from retention work.

2.1 Business models and list ownership

Model	Definition	Owns an emailable list?	Ascent fit	Lhotse fit
DTC brand	Makes or owns its products; sells mainly through its own site or app	Yes, fully	Strong	Strong
DNVB	A DTC brand born online that controls the product from design to sale	Yes	Strong	Strong , if cash is sound
Subscription-first DTC	Core revenue is recurring orders, often through ReCharge	Yes	Strong	Strong (churn and dunning flows)
Omnichannel retailer	Own stores, website, marketplaces and wholesale, with shared data	Web buyers yes; store buyers partly	Strong (enterprise repairs)	Conditional: size on web revenue
Hybrid Amazon + DTC	Material revenue on Amazon and on its own site	Only DTC buyers	Conditional	Conditional: the DTC site must clear the floor on its own

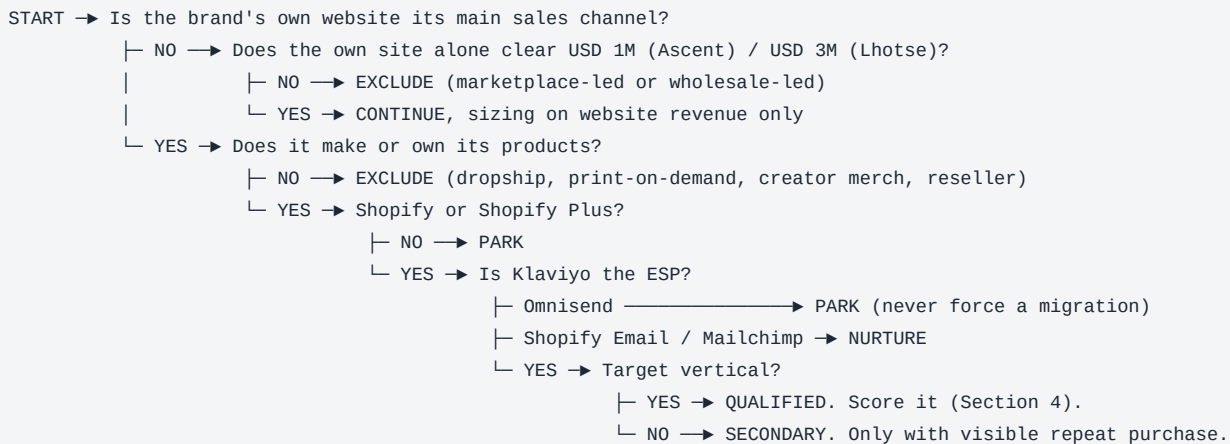
Model	Definition	Owns an emailable list?	Ascent fit	Lhotse fit
Wholesale-led brand	Retail partners bring most revenue	Small DTC list	Only if DTC ≥ USD 1M	Exclude
Marketplace-only seller	Sells through Amazon, Etsy or TikTok Shop	No. The marketplace masks buyer emails.	Exclude	Exclude
Dropshipper	Holds no stock; a supplier ships each order	Technically	Exclude	Exclude
Print-on-demand / creator merch	Printed to order (Printful, Printify, Fourthwall)	Rarely brand-owned	Exclude	Exclude

"E-commerce" in the Census sense covers any retail sale ordered online, from Amazon to a two-person Shopify store. Only the rows marked Strong or Conditional are GrowMailers' market. ShipBob's 2026 survey found 65% of brands name their own website as their top channel, 20% name Amazon and 12% name retail or wholesale. Because 86% of brands sell on two or more channels, **always size a prospect on website revenue**. Amazon and wholesale revenue never passes through Klaviyo.

2.2 Why dropshippers and print-on-demand are excluded

Retention email works when customers run out of a product and trust the brand enough to reorder. Dropshipped generic goods have neither. Their thin margins cannot fund USD 36,000 a year of retention work, many of these stores close within months (Ascent's value depends on a domain the brand keeps for years), and cheap traffic brings low-quality subscribers who damage both results and case studies. They are easy to screen out. Printful and Printify are top-ten apps on US Shopify stores, and Fourthwall accounts for 7.0% of US stores running Klaviyo.

2.3 Qualification decision tree



2.4 Edge cases

- **A USD 25M brand doing 60% on Amazon.** Its website makes USD 10M, which is a Lhotse-band site. Qualify it on that figure, and expect a low email share because Amazon buyers never joined the list.
- **A retailer with physical stores.** A strong Ascent candidate, because more sending tools mean more authentication gaps. For Lhotse, check whether store customers are captured into Klaviyo at checkout. Report email share against web revenue only.
- **A holding company with several brands.** Each brand has its own domain, list and reputation, so each is a separate Ascent project. Sell to the group once.

- **A subscription-heavy brand.** Renewals are not attributed to email, so email share looks low. Judge the program on churn prevention and cross-sell instead.
- **A headless Shopify Plus build.** Tech-detection tools miss its apps. Confirm the stack by subscribing and reading the email headers (Section 18).

3. Macro Industry Pressures & Customer Acquisition Economics

Bottom line: Online retail keeps growing, but the cost of winning each customer is growing faster than the margin on their first order. At current ad inflation, a median apparel brand's first order slips into loss within two years. Retention is where DTC brands make their money, and that is the case GrowMailers sells.

3.1 Market scale

The US Census Bureau reports USD 340.2 billion of US e-commerce in Q2 2026, which is 17.1% of all retail and 12.2% more than a year earlier. Full-year 2025 came to about USD 1.23 trillion (up about 5.4%). eMarketer puts DTC at about 19% of US e-commerce, roughly USD 234 billion, and expects the share to stay flat to 2028. Growth sped up in 2026, but Census figures include price rises, so tariff pass-through explains part of it. Brands are selling more dollars' worth of goods, not necessarily more units, and not at better margins.

3.2 Paid media inflation

Meta's Q2 2026 results showed average price per ad up 12%, with impressions up 14%. At flat conversion rates, that means roughly 12% more ad spend per purchase. Google Shopping and Search are also auctions and move the same way, so for those channels use the prospect's own ad account as the benchmark. Here is what compounding does to the apparel economics in Section 1.4, where about USD 44.86 is available before acquisition:

Year	Cost per purchase at +12% a year	Left from the first order
Today	USD 39.24	USD 5.62
+1 year	USD 43.95	USD 0.91
+2 years	USD 49.22	–USD 4.36
+3 years	USD 55.13	–USD 10.27

Our estimate, assuming flat conversion and flat order value.

Nothing breaks visibly. The first order just earns a little less each month until it quietly starts losing money. Brands that already earn their profit from repeat orders can absorb this, and brands that don't will find their growth plan stops adding up.

3.3 Tariffs and landed cost

The trade rules changed several times in 2026. The US Supreme Court struck down one set of tariffs in February, and a temporary 10% surcharge followed. New tariffs of 10% to 12.5% on about 60 economies took effect on 24 July, with Canada and the UK at 10%. US Customs suspended duty-free entry for low-value parcels indefinitely, and the USD 800 exemption ends by law on 1 July 2027. Importing brands absorb a higher cost of goods, and Canadian, UK and Australian brands shipping to US customers now pay duties they did not pay before. Trade press put several 2025 DTC closures down to this mix of tariffs, inflation, scarcer capital and high acquisition costs.

3.4 CAC, CPA and payback

- **CPA** is ad spend divided by all purchases, new and returning. Triple Whale's medians use this definition.
- **CAC** is marketing spend divided by *new* customers only, so it is always higher than CPA.
- **Contribution per order** is revenue minus product, fulfilment and payment costs.

Payback (orders) = New-customer CAC ÷ Contribution per order before acquisition

Beauty example: CAC ≈ USD 50 (1.5 × median CPA of USD 33.44)

Contribution ≈ USD 38.93 (Section 8) → payback ≈ 1.3 orders

Across the verticals in Section 8, beauty, supplements and apparel need about 1.3 to 1.6 orders to recover CAC. Food and pet need about 2.2 to 2.5. **In every target vertical, profit depends on repeat orders.**

3.5 The retention math

Retention work adds profit through three levers: **repeat rate** (the share of buyers who come back), **frequency** (how quickly they return) and **contribution per repeat order** (bundles, cross-sell and discount discipline). Take a USD 8M beauty brand that acquires 50,000 new customers a year. Lifting its 12-month repeat rate from 25% to 30% adds 2,500 repeat customers. At 1.4 repeat orders each and about USD 39 of contribution per order, that is roughly **USD 136,000 of extra contribution a year** (our illustration). That is two to four times Lhotse's annual fee, from one lever alone.

3.6 What this means for the pitch

- **Talk about contribution margin, not open rates.** "Orders you don't pay Meta for" lands with founders and CFOs.
- **Compare Lhotse with buying the same orders through ads.** At a USD 40 blended CPA, 150 extra repeat orders a month would cost USD 6,000 in ad spend, which is more than Lhotse.
- **Avoid claims without a source.** The popular line that "CAC rose 60% in five years" comes from a 2022 vendor press release with no stated method. Senior buyers have seen it before.

4. E-Commerce Tech Stack Ecosystem & Intelligence Signals

Bottom line: A brand's installed apps show its size, budget and likely pain before anyone speaks to it. Shopify plus Klaviyo is the entry ticket. Klaviyo plus at least one paid growth tool marks a brand with a retention budget. Attentive, Northbeam and Shopify Plus are the strongest size signals. We turn these signals into two scores: a **Lhotse Fit Score** and an **Ascent Urgency Score**.

4.1 The DTC stack

STOREFRONT	Shopify · Shopify Plus (USD 2,300–2,500/mo)
OWNED CHANNELS	Klaviyo · Postscript · Attentive · Omnisend · others
REVENUE MODEL	ReCharge (subscriptions) · loyalty and referral apps
MEASUREMENT	Triple Whale · Northbeam
CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE	Gorgias (support) · Okendo / Yotpo (reviews)
OPERATIONS	3PL (84% of brands use one) · inventory · returns

Every tool that emails as the brand (support, reviews, subscriptions) is another sender that must pass DMARC alignment, so each is an Ascent checkpoint.

4.2 What each tool signals

Tool	Share of US Shopify stores	Signal	What it tells us	Offer angle
Shopify Plus	2.5%	Strong (size)	USD 27,600 to 30,000 a year in fees, which is 2.8% of revenue at USD 1M, so almost always a USD 1M+ brand	Both
Klaviyo	14.5%	Gate	Required. About 64% of US Shopify stores with a detectable ESP use it.	Both
Attentive	0.58%	Strong (size)	Enterprise-leaning, high volume, big SMS budget	Ascent; Lhotse Scale
Northbeam	0.11%	Strong (size)	Large ad budget and a measurement-literate team	Lead with incrementality
Postscript	1.7%	Medium	Runs SMS; has a retention budget	Lhotse Growth
ReCharge	2.1%	Medium	Repeat-purchase model already in place	Churn, dunning, cross-sell
Triple Whale	1.3%	Medium	Watches blended efficiency closely	Frame results as MER impact
Gorgias	1.0%	Medium	Has a CX team that sends from the brand domain	DMARC alignment check
Mailchimp	5.8%	Weak	Rarely a scaled DTC program	Nurture
Omnisend alone	2.2%	Neutral	Often a deliberate choice, especially in Australia	Park; never force a migration
Printful / Printify / Fourthwall	Top-10 apps	Exclusion	Print-on-demand model	Exclude

Our division of Store Leads counts by 1,179,951 live US Shopify stores (September 2026).

Three platform facts shape the pitch. **Klaviyo is growing into the mid-market.** Its Q2 2026 revenue rose 26% to USD 370.6M, and customers paying it more than USD 50,000 a year grew 36% to 4,477. Bigger brands are putting more money into owned channels. **Shopify Email rewrites the sender** to shopifyemail.com when a domain is unauthenticated or has no DMARC record or two of them. The rewrite is visible from outside, which makes it a clean Ascent finding. **Owners value Klaviyo's power but resent its bills.** Complaints centre on cost and complexity, so GrowMailers sells the expertise that makes Klaviyo worth paying for, never a migration.

4.3 Intent-scoring formulas

Lhotse Fit Score (LFS, 0 to 100)

LFS = Platform (0-20) + Size (0-30) + Stack (0-20) + Vertical (0-15) + Program Gap (0-15) - Penalties
 GATE: no Klaviyo → LFS = 0 (park or nurture)

Component	Criteria	Points
Platform	Shopify Plus / standard Shopify ≥ USD 250k a month / below that	20 / 12 / 0
Size (estimated monthly sales)	USD 420k to 1.0M (USD 5M to 12M a year)	30
	USD 1.0M to 1.67M (USD 12M to 20M) / USD 250k to 420k (USD 3M to 5M)	25 / 20
	Above USD 1.67M / below USD 250k	10 / 5
Stack (cap 20)	Postscript or Attentive +6; ReCharge +6; Triple Whale or Northbeam +5; Gorgias +3; reviews or loyalty app +3	up to 20
Vertical	Beauty, supplements, food and beverage, pet / apparel or home with replenishable lines / other	15 / 8 / 3
Program gap (cap 15, from the audit)	Welcome is one email or missing +5; full-list campaigns more than 4 a week +4; no browse abandonment +3; no post-purchase or replenishment +3	up to 15
Penalties	Unverified registered-agent address -20; hired an email agency in the last 6 months -10; marketplace-led, dropship or print-on-demand → exclude	

Ascent Urgency Score (AUS, 0 to 100)

Component	Criteria	Points
Authentication gaps (cap 40)	No DMARC record 20; two or malformed DMARC records 20; shared Klaviyo domain ("via klaviyomail.com") with more than 5,000 profiles 20; Shopify sender rewrite 15; SPF over 10 lookups or duplicated 10	up to 40
Exposure (cap 30)	List above 50,000 10; Attentive or Postscript plus daily cadence 10; Microsoft-heavy market (UK, Canada, Australia) 5; Black Friday within 12 weeks 5	up to 30
Visible symptoms (cap 30)	Test emails in spam at 2+ providers 15; transactional mail in spam 10; no one-click unsubscribe header 10; welcome email more than 1 hour late 5	up to 30

Priority matrix

		ASCENT URGENCY SCORE	
		Low (< 40)	High (≥ 40)
LHOTSE FIT SCORE	High (≥60)	LHOTSE-FIRST Lead with program gaps and upside	ASCENT NOW, LHOTSE NEXT Fix base, then pitch
	Low (<60)	NURTURE / DISCARD Re-score quarterly	ASCENT ONLY USD 1-3M or USD 20M+

4.4 Verify before outreach

Tech databases lag and miss headless builds. Before outreach, confirm three things by hand: Klaviyo is live (its script is on the site, or its headers appear in a real email), mail actually arrives after sign-up, and the growth tools are visible on the site (a ReCharge portal, a Gorgias chat widget). A stale signal leads to a wrong pitch. Market context matters too. **Australia has the highest Klaviyo penetration of our markets, at 23.6% of Shopify stores against 14.5% in the US**, and Klaviyo's revenue outside the Americas grew 35% in Q2 2026. Australian and UK buyers are more experienced, so lead there with deliverability depth and measurement rather than flow basics.

5. Target Audience Specification & Multi-Tier ICP Definitions

Bottom line: Our ICP is a Shopify or Shopify Plus brand on Klaviyo that owns its products and its list, sells mainly through its own site, and operates in beauty, supplements, food and beverage or pet. **Lhotse** targets USD 3M to 20M in annual revenue. That is the band where email earns USD 600k to 6M a year and a USD 36k to 66k retainer beats a USD 70k to 100k+ hire. **Ascent** targets USD 1M to 50M+, including enterprise brands with internal teams that need a specialist, zero-downtime repair.

5.1 Hard gates

Gate	Requirement	How we verify it
Platform	Shopify or Shopify Plus	Store Leads; storefront source
ESP	Klaviyo installed and sending	Subscribe and read the headers
List ownership	Own website is the main channel	Site review; Amazon is not the main call to action
Product ownership	Makes or owns its products	No dropship or print-on-demand apps; branded product pages
Revenue floor	USD 1M+ (Ascent) or the vertical floor (Lhotse) in website revenue	Store Leads estimated monthly sales
Geography	US, UK, Canada, Australia, Ireland or NZ, confirmed as the real operating base	Address, phone, founder profile, shipping origin
Lawful contact	A compliant route to a decision maker (Section 17)	Contact source recorded

5.2 Ascent tiers

	A1: Emerging	A2: Growth	A3: Enterprise Repair
Annual revenue	USD 1M to 3M	USD 3M to 20M	USD 20M to 50M+
Estimated monthly sales	USD 83k to 250k	USD 250k to 1.67M	USD 1.67M to 4.2M+
Typical staff	3 to 10	8 to 40	40 to 80+
Working SKU range	10 to 80	30 to 300	100 to 1,000+
Active Klaviyo profiles	10k to 40k	40k to 250k	250k to 1M+
Monthly email sends	50k to 250k	250k to 1.5M	1.5M to 8M+
Who signs	Founder	Founder below USD 5M; VP Marketing above	CMO or VP; finance reviews

	A1: Emerging	A2: Growth	A3: Enterprise Repair
Typical trigger	Shopify rewrite, shared Klaviyo domain, bots, rising bill	Microsoft spam placement, bounce spikes, peak worry	Domain migration, DMARC enforcement, incident recovery
Ascent angle	"Fix the foundations once, for under 0.5% of revenue"	"Protect the channel that earns you USD 1M+ a year"	"A zero-downtime specialist repair your team can hand off"

Staff ranges draw on Eightx data for online-first brands. SKU, profile and send ranges are GrowMailers qualification ranges. No public source reports list size by revenue band.

5.3 Lhotse tiers

	L1: Entry	L2: Core (sweet spot)	L3: Scale
Annual revenue	USD 3M to 5M	USD 5M to 12M	USD 12M to 20M
Email revenue at 20% to 30%	USD 600k to 1.5M	USD 1.0M to 3.6M	USD 2.4M to 6.0M
Suggested band	Core (USD 3,000 to 3,500)	Growth (USD 3,500 to 4,500)	Scale (USD 4,500 to 5,500)
Retainer as share of email revenue	2.4% to 7%	1.2% to 5.4%	0.9% to 2.8%
Decision maker	Founder	VP Marketing or Head of Growth	CMO or VP; retention lead influences
Competing alternative	Freelancer, or the founder doing it	The first in-house hire	In-house team plus agency
Core pitch	"A full retention team for less than one hire"	"Stop hiring for skills you need part-time"	"Strategy, deliverability and testing your team has no time for"

Below USD 3M, Lhotse would take 12% to 22% of a USD 1.5M brand's email revenue. Sell Ascent and revisit later. **Above USD 20M**, brands usually have in-house retention teams, and Ascent is the right way in.

Vertical-adjusted Lhotse floors (from the unit economics in Section 8):

Vertical	Lhotse floor	Reason
Beauty and personal care	USD 3M	About USD 39 contribution per repeat order
Health and supplements	USD 3M	High margin and a 30-day reorder cycle
Pet supplies	USD 4M	About USD 22 per repeat order
Food and beverage	USD 5M	About USD 17 per repeat order

A food or pet brand with an average order value above about USD 90, or a strong subscription base, can qualify at USD 3M.

5.4 Why these four verticals

US Klaviyo users over-index in these categories compared with all Shopify stores: beauty and fitness at 12.8% against 10.9%, food and drink at 8.8% against 7.1%, and health at 7.3% against 4.4%. Their customers run out of the product and come back, so owned channels pay.

Vertical	Planning reorder cycle	Flows that earn most	Watch-outs
Beauty and personal care	30 to 75 days	Quiz-led welcome, replenishment, reviews, VIP	Shade returns; discount culture
Health and supplements	30 days	Replenishment, subscription save and dunning, education	Health claims are regulated (FTC, ASA, TGA)

Vertical	Planning reorder cycle	Flows that earn most	Watch-outs
Food and beverage	14 to 45 days	Back-in-stock, replenishment, seasonal	Low margin, perishability, shipping cost
Pet supplies	30 to 45 days	Replenishment, pet birthday, win-back	Chewy and Amazon Subscribe & Save

Reorder cycles are planning assumptions. Replace them with each brand's median days between orders. Apparel is the largest category (29.1% of US Shopify stores) and a secondary target. It fits when repeat purchase is visible, as with basics, uniforms or restockable essentials.

5.5 Exclusion rules

Rule	How to detect it	Action
Marketplace-only or marketplace-led	No real own-site checkout; "Buy on Amazon" as the main call to action	Exclude
Dropshipper	DSers, Zendrop, AutoDS or CJdropshipping apps; 2 to 4 week shipping; generic products	Exclude
Print-on-demand or creator merch	Printful, Printify, Fourthwall or Spring	Exclude
Non-owner merchant models	Resellers, affiliates, or white-label stores where a distributor owns the customer	Exclude
No ESP, or Mailchimp with no automation	No welcome email after sign-up	Nurture
Registered-agent address	Address matches a known agent; founder based abroad	Verify, then re-tag or exclude
Below the floor	Estimated sales under USD 83k a month, or under the vertical floor	Nurture; re-score quarterly
USD 50M+ with an in-house team	CRM job posts; large team	Ascent repair projects only
Personal Gmail as the only contact (Canada, UK, Ireland)	Contact data	Do not cold email
Hired an email agency in the last 6 months	Agency credits, announcements	Nurture; revisit in 9 to 12 months

5.6 Portrait of an ideal Lhotse client

An illustrative composite. A USD 7M supplements brand in Austin on Shopify Plus, with 85% of revenue from its own site. It has 18 staff and a three-person marketing team under a Head of Growth. Its stack is Klaviyo, Postscript, ReCharge, Triple Whale and Gorgias. The list holds 95,000 profiles, but only about 35,000 have clicked or bought in six months. The welcome series is two emails. There is no replenishment flow, even though 60% of revenue comes from 30-day products. Email is 14% of website revenue. **It scores about 85 on LFS and 35 on AUS, which makes it a Lhotse-first account.** The first quarter would build replenishment and post-purchase flows, move campaigns to engaged segments, suppress roughly 40,000 dormant profiles (cutting the Klaviyo bill), and set up a holdout test so the Head of Growth can show the founder real incremental revenue.

6. Addressable Market Sizing & Geolocation Deep-Dive

Bottom line: The serviceable pool, anchored on Shopify Plus, is roughly **4,500 brands across six countries**, two-thirds of them in the US. At a mid-point Lhotse fee that is about USD 230M a year in retainer value, and GrowMails needs well under 1% of it. The constraint is focus and timing, not market size. Registered-agent hubs such as Sheridan, Wyoming (20,043 Shopify stores) show why every list needs geographic cleaning.

6.1 The store base

Country	Live Shopify stores	Shopify Plus stores	Stores with Klaviyo	Online share of retail
United States	1,179,951	28,965	203,080	About 16.4% (2025)
United Kingdom	231,312	6,311	43,546	27.5% (2025)
Canada	147,721	3,812	22,584	7.5% (Jul 2026)
Australia	138,276	3,725	35,621	24% (2025)
New Zealand	26,522	581	5,322	n/a
Ireland	12,873	502	2,786	5.7% (Jul 2026, Irish retailers)
Total	1,736,655	43,896	312,939	

Store Leads, 18 September 2026. Klaviyo counts cover all platforms. Each country measures online share differently, so treat that column as a rough guide.

6.2 From stores to serviceable brands

Shopify Plus stores (six countries)	43,896	
÷ 1.5 store domains per merchant		
Distinct Plus merchants	≈ 29,263	
× 60% on Klaviyo		← planning assumption
Plus merchants on Klaviyo (TAM base)	≈ 17,558	
× 30% in our four verticals		← Klaviyo category mix
Target-vertical merchants	≈ 5,268	
× 85% after exclusions		← marketplace-led, POD, registry shells
SERVICEABLE POOL (SAM base)	≈ 4,478 brands	

Country	Plus merchants	On Klaviyo	Target verticals	Serviceable pool	Share
United States	19,310	11,586	3,476	2,955	66%
United Kingdom	4,207	2,524	757	643	14%
Canada	2,541	1,525	458	389	9%
Australia	2,483	1,490	447	380	8%
New Zealand	387	232	70	60	1%
Ireland	335	201	60	51	1%
Total	29,263	17,558	5,268	4,478	100%

Our estimates. Australia's true Klaviyo rate is probably higher, and New Zealand's food-heavy mix (13.0% of stores) probably lifts its vertical share. **This is a floor.** Many USD 1M to 5M brands avoid the Plus fee and are missing from the count. **Validation step:** use GrowMailers' paid Store Leads account to export stores by country, filtered to Klaviyo and our categories, in estimated-sales bands of USD 83k to 833k a month and USD 833k to 1.67M a month. Then replace these assumptions with real counts.

Layer	Definition	Brands	Annual value
TAM	Plus merchants on Klaviyo, any vertical, at a USD 51k Lhotse mid-point	≈ 17,558	≈ USD 895M
SAM	Serviceable pool in our verticals	≈ 4,478	≈ USD 228M retainer value + ≈ USD 22M one-time Ascent value
SOM (12 to 24 months)	12 to 20 Lhotse clients and 30 to 50 Ascent projects a year	42 to 70	≈ USD 0.76M to 1.27M a year (0.3% to 0.5% of SAM)

Our planning scenario. SOM is limited by delivery capacity, not by demand.

6.3 Country roles

Country	GTM role	Key hubs	Mailbox risk	Playbook note
United States	Primary, year-round (≈ 2,955 brands)	California, New York, Florida, Texas, New Jersey, Utah	Gmail-heavy (54.4%)	Most permissive B2B email law
United Kingdom	Secondary; strongest in Q1 (≈ 643)	London (52,471 stores)	Microsoft holds 32.3%	Test Microsoft placement in every audit
Australia	Secondary; Jan to Mar and Jul to Aug (≈ 380)	New South Wales, Victoria	Microsoft holds 30.2%	Most mature Klaviyo market; lead with depth
Canada	Selective (≈ 389)	Ontario (44.7%), Quebec (19.5%)	Microsoft holds 27.9%	Strictest law (CASL); Quebec's 28,853 stores need French
Ireland	Add-on to UK (≈ 51)	Dublin	Microsoft-heavy (assumed)	Company addresses only
New Zealand	Add-on to Australia (≈ 60)	Auckland (11,232 stores)	No public data	Food brands are 13.0% of stores

6.4 US state targeting

State	Stores with 10 to 49 staff	Klaviyo rate	Note
California	3,407	16.6%	Largest cluster; beauty and wellness
New York	1,730	not read	Fashion and beauty density
Florida	1,134	14.8%	Many stores, few brand-sized. Filter tightly.
Texas	983	13.6%	As Florida
New Jersey	469	not read	Consumer goods and beauty
Utah	411	18.8%	Highest Klaviyo rate read; supplements cluster
Illinois	398	13.5%	Food and consumer goods
Colorado	380	15.3%	Outdoor, pet, natural products

In Florida, Texas and Georgia, only 1.0% to 1.5% of stores have 10 or more staff, against 3.0% to 3.8% in California and New York. Use stricter revenue filters there.

6.5 Registry traps

Sheridan, Wyoming, a town of under 20,000 people, hosts 20,043 Shopify stores, the third-highest count of any US city. This is not a DTC boom. Founders outside the US form LLCs through registered agents, and the agent's address becomes the store's address. The same thing happens in Cheyenne, Wyoming, in Delaware (Wilmington, Lewes, Dover), in New Mexico, and at mass virtual-office addresses in London.

Screening SOP:

1. Flag any address that matches a known registered-agent or virtual-office location.
2. Check for a local phone number, a real returns address and the stated shipping origin.
3. Find where the founder and team actually work, using LinkedIn or the About page.
4. If the real base is outside our six countries, exclude the account. If it is inside, re-tag it to the real country and apply that country's law.
5. Log the check in the CRM.

6.6 Coverage from Nepal

For a team working in Nepal time (NPT, UTC+5:45):

Market	Local 09:00 to 17:00 in Nepal time	Approach
UK and Ireland	13:45 to 21:45 (BST) / 14:45 to 22:45 (GMT)	Best overlap. Live calls in the afternoon.
Australia (Sydney, Melbourne)	04:45 to 12:45 (AEST) / 03:45 to 11:45 (AEDT)	Call Australian afternoons during the Nepal morning
New Zealand (Auckland)	02:45 to 10:45 (NZST) / 01:45 to 09:45 (NZDT)	Nepal mornings; schedule emails
US and Canada Eastern	18:45 to 02:45 (EDT) / 19:45 to 03:45 (EST)	Evening call shift; schedule emails
US and Canada Pacific	21:45 to 05:45 (PDT) / 22:45 to 06:45 (PST)	Late calls; schedule emails

Schedule every outreach email to arrive between 08:00 and 10:00 in the recipient's time zone.

7. Organizational Structures & Decision-Maker Buying Profiles

Bottom line: Below USD 5M the founder signs. From USD 5M to 20M a marketing leader signs and a retention lead influences the decision. Above USD 20M finance reviews the contract. Founders need to hear about cash and margin, growth leaders about blended efficiency, and CRM leads about relief from workload and risk. Lhotse starts competing with a salary at the point where a brand would hire its first email manager, usually between USD 3M and 8M.

7.1 How teams change with scale

Revenue	Marketing team	Budget share to agencies	Who runs email	Who signs
USD 1M to 3M	2 to 3 people	about 5%	Founder or freelancer	Founder
USD 3M to 8M	4 to 6, including an email manager	about 7%	First email hire	Founder
USD 8M to 20M	7 to 12	about 7%	Retention lead	VP Marketing, CMO or Head of Growth
USD 20M to 50M	15 to 25, led by a VP or CMO	about 5%	Head of Retention and team	CMO or VP; finance reviews

Recruiter and agency guides (ATTN, eCommerce Placement). No independent survey exists.

Between about USD 3M and 15M, brands move from needing a "Klaviyo specialist" to needing a "lifecycle strategist". Many have someone who can build a flow but nobody who can design a retention strategy, and Lhotse fills that gap. Marketing spend also shrinks as a share of revenue with scale. Brands under USD 5M are estimated to spend 30% to 45%, while ten public consumer brands spend a median of 13.3%. Smaller brands feel every dollar, so L1 has to be sold as a cost-saver.



7.2 Buyer profiles

	Founder / CEO	VP Marketing / Head of Growth	CMO	CRM / Retention Lead
Owns	Cash, margin, strategy, exit	Growth against total marketing spend	Brand, growth, team, board story	Flows, campaigns, list health, deliverability
Top KPIs	Cash, contribution margin, MER	MER, new-customer revenue, CAC	Growth, LTV to CAC, team productivity	Flow revenue, email share, spam and bounce rates
Main fear	Paying an agency that over-promises	Missing target as ad costs rise	A public failure at peak	Being blamed for an incident; burnout
What they need to hear	"Here's the cost, the payback, and how you'll know."	"Owned revenue lowers blended CAC. Here's the MER impact."	"Specialist depth, measured by holdout, no risk to peak."	"We take the grunt work and fix what you haven't had time for."
Proof they trust	A model built with their own numbers	Holdout-tested lift	Case studies at their scale	Technical findings and a clear SOP
Best lead offer	Ascent A1 or Lhotse Core	Lhotse Growth	Ascent A3, then Lhotse Scale	Ascent, positioned as their ally
Deal-killers	Vague promises, long lock-ins	Vanity metrics	A junior team, no risk plan	Anything that threatens their role

7.3 Objection-handling playbook

Objection	Behind it	Response	Proof
"We already have an agency."	Inertia, sometimes quiet dissatisfaction	"No need to switch. Ascent is a one-time technical repair most agencies don't do. Here's what your headers show."	External audit
"We'll do it in-house."	Belief that a hire is cheaper	"A good hire costs USD 85k to 135k fully loaded and brings one skill set. Lhotse is USD 36k to 66k for a team."	Section 1.3 comparison
"Our open rates are fine."	Opens inflated by Apple MPP	"Apple auto-opens most mail. Let's look at clicks and placed orders."	Section 10 benchmarks
"Klaviyo says deliverability is fine."	Averages hide problem providers	"About a third of UK, Canadian and Australian inboxes are Microsoft. Let's check by provider."	Provider-level check
"Not now, it's Black Friday prep."	A genuine freeze	"Agreed, no retainer now. Here are two freeze-safe fixes, and let's book January."	Section 16 fix list
"Too expensive."	Unclear ROI or tight cash	"At your margins, Lhotse needs about 80 to 140 extra repeat orders a month. You do 6,000."	Section 8 breakeven

Objection	Behind it	Response	Proof
"An agency failed us before."	Past over-promising	"What did they measure? We report holdout-tested lift, not platform credit."	Sample holdout report
"Isn't DMARC at p=none a fail?"	Scare tactics from past vendors	"No, p=none meets every mailbox provider's rules. Enforcement is best practice, done carefully."	Section 13

8. Financial Dynamics, Margin Structures & Category Unit Economics

Bottom line: In every target vertical, the first paid-media order barely breaks even or loses money, and profit begins with the second order. Beauty and supplements have the margins that let Lhotse pay for itself fastest: it needs incremental orders equal to only about 1% to 2.5% of a mid-size brand's monthly orders. Food and pet earn less per order, so their Lhotse floor is higher. Discounting in flows can wipe out a third of a repeat order's contribution, which makes managing discounts part of the Lhotse job.

8.1 What real DTC financials show

Company (year)	Revenue	Gross margin	Marketing spend	Profit
FIGS, US apparel (FY2025)	USD 631.1M	66.5%	14.8% of revenue	Net 5.4%
Hims & Hers, US telehealth (FY2025)	USD 2,347.6M	74%	39% of revenue	Net 5.5%
Temple & Webster, AU home (FY26)	A\$665M	30.2% (delivered)	15.2% of revenue	EBITDA 3.3%

Even at scale and with strong gross margins, DTC net margins sit around 5%. The durable ones are built on repeat customers. At Temple & Webster, 62% of FY26 orders came from repeat customers. FIGS earns about USD 216 per active customer a year, and Hims & Hers about USD 81 per subscriber a month.

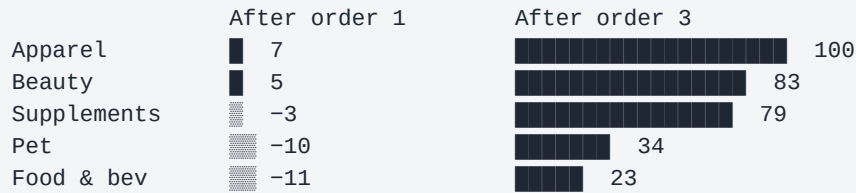
8.2 Unit economics by vertical

Vertical	Median order value	Gross margin*	Fulfillment and payments*	Median ad cost per purchase	First-order contribution	Repeat-order contribution
Apparel	USD 103.37	60%	15%	USD 39.24	USD 7.27	USD 46.51
Beauty	USD 68.29	72%	15%	USD 33.44	USD 5.49	USD 38.93
Supplements	USD 71.26	72%	14%	USD 44.81	-USD 3.48	USD 41.33
Food and beverage	USD 69.87	45%	20%	USD 28.96	-USD 11.49	USD 17.47
Pet	USD 69.95	50%	18%	USD 32.68	-USD 10.29	USD 22.39

Order values and ad costs are Triple Whale medians for US DTC brands (90 days to 21 September 2026, its own customers). *Gross margin and fulfillment rates are GrowMails planning assumptions, more conservative than the FIGS example in Section 1.4. Replace them with the prospect's real numbers during discovery.* Triple Whale's ad cost figure includes returning buyers, so the true first-order contribution is *worse* than shown.

8.3 LTV curves

CUMULATIVE CONTRIBUTION PER CUSTOMER (USD, one block ≈ USD 5; ▨ = loss)



Vertical	12-month expected orders	12-month contribution	24-month expected orders	24-month contribution
Apparel	1.4	USD 25.87	1.7	USD 39.83
Beauty	1.6	USD 28.85	2.1	USD 48.31
Supplements	2.2	USD 46.12	3.0	USD 79.18
Food and beverage	2.0	USD 5.98	2.8	USD 19.96
Pet	2.3	USD 18.82	3.3	USD 41.21

Expected order counts are planning assumptions. No method-backed public benchmark for repeat rate by category exists, and the widely quoted "25% to 30%" traces back to blog posts. Use each brand's own cohort data.

Supplements has the strongest 12- and 24-month economics, because its 30-day reorder cycle quickly turns a slightly negative first order positive. Food is thin at every step and only scales through frequency and bigger baskets. That is why replenishment timing and bundles matter most in food and pet.

8.4 What Lhotse and Ascent must earn

Vertical	Repeat contribution	Lhotse at USD 3,000/mo	Lhotse at USD 5,500/mo	Ascent (USD 5,000 once)
Apparel	USD 46.51	65 orders/mo	119 orders/mo	108 orders
Beauty	USD 38.93	78	142	129
Supplements	USD 41.33	73	134	121
Food and beverage	USD 17.47	172	315	287
Pet	USD 22.39	134	246	224

In context: a USD 5M beauty brand does about 6,100 orders a month, so Lhotse needs 78 to 142 of them to be *incremental*, or 1.3% to 2.3%. A USD 5M food brand does about 5,960 orders and needs 172 to 315, or 2.9% to 5.3%. That is achievable but demanding, which is why the food floor is USD 5M and why holdout testing matters most in low-margin verticals.

8.5 Sensitivity: what moves the model

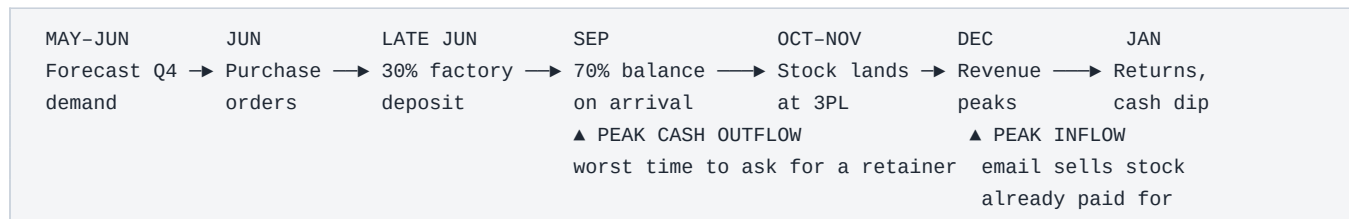
Lever	Change	Effect (beauty)
Repeat rate	+5 points on a 25% base	About 20% more repeat orders
Repeat order value	+10% through bundles	Contribution per repeat order rises from USD 38.93 to about USD 43.85
Frequency	Reminder moved from day 45 to day 38 for a 40-day product	Catches buyers before they switch brands
Discount leakage	20% off every repeat order	Contribution falls from USD 38.93 to USD 25.27 (-35%)

Many brands put a 15% to 20% code in every flow email out of habit. On a USD 68 beauty order, 20% off removes USD 13.66 of revenue while product and shipping costs stay the same. Saving discounts for win-back, first-order conversion and peak, and using education and social proof elsewhere, can add more profit than any new flow. **In sales:** rebuild this model live on every discovery call using the prospect's own numbers. When their spreadsheet shows Lhotse needs only 1% to 3% of monthly orders, the price objection usually goes away.

9. Operational Cycles & the Annual E-Commerce Cash Calendar

Bottom line: Brands pay for fourth-quarter stock in summer, so cash is tightest in August and September and most plentiful in January and February. That cycle, more than any marketing calendar, decides when a founder will sign a retainer. Sell Lhotse when budgets reset and cash returns. Sell Ascent's fast, low-risk fixes when pressure is high.

9.1 The inventory cash cycle



That last point gives Ascent a cash argument in the fourth quarter: *every order lost to the spam folder is inventory you have already paid for.*

9.2 Month-by-month calendar

Month	Cash and inventory	Brand focus	Pitch window	GrowMailers motion
January	Returns land (US online returns were 19.3% in 2025); new budgets	Post-peak review; resolutions (supplements)	★★★★★	Best window. Lhotse on post-peak data; Ascent for December bounce victims
February	Recovering	Valentine's Day; Mothering Sunday prep (UK and Ireland)	★★★★★	Lhotse starts
March	Stable	Mothering Sunday (7 Mar 2027); Easter	★★★★	Lhotse for US, Canada and non-gifting brands; Ascent everywhere
April	Stable; UK tax year starts	Mother's Day build	★★★★	Both; Australian brands plan EOFY
May	Q4 forecasting	Mother's Day (9 May 2027); Australian EOFY prep	★★★	Australian brands must be ready by early May
June	Q4 orders and deposits go out	Father's Day; Australian EOFY sales	★★★★	Second window opens: Black Friday readiness
July	Tightening; Australian budgets reset	Prime Day; US back-to-school	★★★★	Lhotse starts still have time for peak; Ascent domain projects
August	Tight; stock in transit	Black Friday planning and audits	★★★	Ascent first; last Lhotse starts that can be fully peak-ready
September	Peak cash outflow	Peak creative and segmentation	★★	Last call; new sending domains start warming by mid-September

Month	Cash and inventory	Brand focus	Pitch window	GrowMailers motion
October	Stock arrives; setup locks	Prime Big Deal Days; volume ramp	★	Freeze-safe Ascent fixes until about 16 October
November	Change freeze	Black Friday and Cyber Monday	☆	No pitching. Book January starts.
December	Peak revenue	Shipping cut-offs; Boxing Day	☆	Book January. December pain feeds January pitches.

9.3 Fiscal-year differences and cash signals

The US and Canada mostly run calendar fiscal years, so January is their buying moment. Some UK and Irish brands reset budgets in April. **Australia runs July to June**, which gives two good windows, January to March and July to August after EOFY. New Zealand often runs April to March.

Outside signal	What it suggests	Implication
Heavy discounting in August and September emails	Excess stock or a cash squeeze	Lead with Ascent or margin protection; delay the Lhotse pitch
Pre-orders or "ships in 6 weeks" notices	Cash tied up in inventory	Low-commitment, value-first approach
Product launches and hiring posts	Growth mode	Lhotse, framed as scaling what already works
Funding announcement	Budget and pressure to grow	Lhotse Scale with board-ready reporting
Founder posting about tariffs or ad costs	Margin pressure is front of mind	Lead with retention economics (Sections 3 and 8)

10. Email Marketing Performance Benchmarks & Measurement Systems

Bottom line: Open rates have stopped meaning much, because Apple's privacy feature auto-opens most mail. Judge a program on click rate, placed-order rate, revenue per recipient, share of website revenue and, above all, holdout-tested incremental lift. Healthy DTC brands earn 20% to 30% of website revenue from email and SMS. Below 8%, there is no real program.

10.1 How much revenue email should drive

Email and SMS share of website revenue	Reading	GrowMailers action
Under 8%	No real program	Lhotse full build, flows first
8% to 20%	Underbuilt	Lhotse: flow gaps and segmentation
20% to 30%	Healthy	Lhotse: optimization and testing
30% to 40%	Top quartile	Ascent to protect it; Lhotse Scale if the team is stretched
Above 40%	Check attribution	Often a generous attribution window, heavy discounting or low paid spend

Flypost (50+ DTC brands on Klaviyo); Level CFO puts the median at 18% to 22%.

Always record the attribution window. Klaviyo credits any order within five days of an open or click to email. That overstates email's real effect, and machine opens make it worse. Merchants have publicly reported Klaviyo claiming several times more conversions than they could verify.

10.2 Platform benchmarks

Measure	Klaviyo campaigns	Klaviyo flows	Omnisend campaigns	Omnisend flows
Click rate	1.69%	5.58%	0.74%	4.66%
Placed-order rate	0.97% to 1.34%	1.62% to 2.17%	0.08%	1.49%
Unsubscribe rate	not shown	not shown	0.20%	0.59%

Klaviyo 2026 benchmarks; Omnisend 2025 data. The platforms define clicks and orders differently, so compare a brand only with its own platform's figures. Rule of thumb: on Klaviyo, a campaign placed-order rate well below 1% signals a program problem.

10.3 The Apple MPP distortion

Apple Mail Privacy Protection (MPP) pre-loads messages, which registers an "open" whether or not anyone reads the email. Litmus reported Apple at 62.26% of tracked opens in July 2026, with MPP affecting roughly 55% to 60% of all opens. Omnisend's average open rate rose from 26.6% to 30.7% between 2024 and 2025, driven by machines, not people. The distortion does three kinds of damage. **Engagement segments get polluted** ("opened in 90 days" includes people who never looked), **subject-line tests become unreliable**, and **sunset policies fail** because a machine-opened profile never looks inactive. The fix is to define engagement by clicks, site activity and orders, exclude Apple privacy opens wherever the platform allows it, and treat opens as a diagnostic only. A sudden drop in opens at a single provider still points to a placement problem.

▲ Most trustworthy

INCREMENTAL REVENUE holdout-tested lift (the CFO's number)

REVENUE PER RECIPIENT reach × relevance × conversion

PLACED-ORDER RATE did the email produce purchases?

CLICK RATE did a human engage?

DELIVERABILITY HEALTH bounces, complaints, provider placement

OPEN RATE diagnostic only (distorted by MPP)

▼ Least trustworthy

10.4 Operating targets for a Lhotse client

Metric	Healthy	Act when
Campaign click rate (Klaviyo)	1.5% to 2%+	Below 1% for four weeks
Campaign placed-order rate (Klaviyo)	About 1% or better	Well below 1%
Spam complaint rate	Below 0.05%	Above 0.05% (Klaviyo flags it); above 0.1% (Gmail's line) means act now
Bounce rate	Below 1%	Above 2% (Klaviyo flags it)
Campaign frequency	2 to 5 a week; up to daily at peak	Only with engagement-based targeting

10.5 Incrementality testing

Flow holdout SOP:

1. Add a random split at flow entry: 90% get the flow, 10% get nothing (use 80/20 for smaller brands).
2. Measure orders from both groups over the same window, such as 14 days.
3. Run for at least four weeks, and until the holdout group has 100+ orders.
4. Incremental orders = (mailed conversion – holdout conversion) × mailed recipients.
5. Report platform-attributed and incremental revenue side by side.

Illustration	Mailed (90%)	Holdout (10%)
Entrants per month	18,000	2,000
14-day conversion	4.0% (720 orders)	2.8% (56 orders)
Incremental orders	1.2 points × 18,000 = 216	
At USD 68 order value	USD 14,688 incremental a month , against USD 48,960 platform-attributed	

In this example, about 30% of attributed revenue is truly incremental, and that is still a strong result. A client who hears the honest number from GrowMailsers first will trust every number after it. **Campaign holdouts** work the same way: leave a random 10% out of all campaigns for a month. **Ascent** is measured before and after: placement by provider, Gmail spam rate, bounces and revenue per recipient, compared with the same weeks a year earlier.

Monthly client scorecard: revenue share (with the attribution window stated), flow vs. campaign split, revenue per recipient, holdout results against fees, click and order rates by segment, Gmail spam rate, bounces, DMARC pass rate, net list growth, profiles suppressed and Klaviyo tier.

11. Automated Email Flow Architecture vs. Campaign Blasts

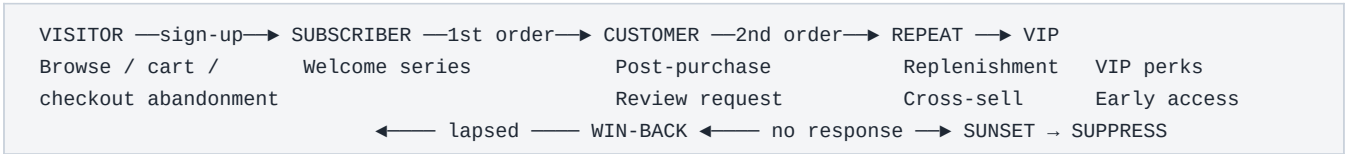
Bottom line: Flows earn far more per email than campaigns. Klaviyo's 2026 data shows flows producing about 41% of email revenue from 5.3% of sends, at nearly 18 times the revenue per recipient. Campaigns still bring in most email revenue, though. A managed program needs both: a complete flow system as the foundation, and a segmented, disciplined campaign calendar on top.

11.1 Flows vs. campaigns

	Flows (behaviour-triggered)	Campaigns (one-off sends)
Share of sends	About 2% to 5%	About 95%
Share of email revenue	About 30% to 41%	About 60% to 70%
Revenue per email (Omnisend)	USD 2.87	USD 0.18
Share of revenue from new buyers	About 48%	About 16%
Deliverability effect	Positive (engaged recipients)	Risky if unsegmented

Nearly half of flow revenue comes from new buyers, so flows also convert new sign-ups. The best brands send fewer campaigns to tighter, engaged segments and put the time saved into their flows.

11.2 Lifecycle map and build order



Abandoned cart and welcome flows produced 76% of all automated orders on Omnisend in 2025. For a brand starting from little, build in this order: abandoned checkout and cart, welcome, browse abandonment, post-purchase and reviews, back-in-stock, **replenishment** (the most important flow for our four verticals), win-back, then VIP, birthday and sunset.

11.3 Flow SOP specifications

Flow	Trigger and filters	Messages and timing	Content	Incentive policy
Welcome	Joins list; exits on first order	4 to 5: immediately, day 1 to 2, day 3 to 4, day 6 to 7, day 10 to 12	Story, best-sellers, proof, education, founder note	First-order offer in email 1 with an expiry reminder; no stacking
Abandoned checkout	Started checkout, no order; 7-day re-entry block	3 (+1 SMS with consent): 1 to 4 hours, 24 hours, 48 to 72 hours	Cart contents, reassurance, objection handling	Offer in the last message only, first-time buyers only
Abandoned cart	Added to cart, no checkout	2: 2 to 4 hours, 24 hours	Product and reviews	None
Browse abandonment	Viewed product (identified); capped at 1 per 7 to 14 days	2: 2 to 6 hours, 24 to 48 hours	Viewed item, alternatives	None
Post-purchase	Order placed or fulfilled; first-time vs. repeat split	3 to 5 over about 30 days	Thanks, how-to, review request at 10 to 21 days after delivery, cross-sell at 21 to 30 days	Loyalty or referral, not discounts
Replenishment	Days since purchase of a consumable; exits on reorder	2 to 3, starting about 7 days before run-out	"Running low?", one-click reorder, subscribe-and-save	Subscription discount only
Back-in-stock	Alert request; stock above threshold	1 to 2 (+SMS) on restock	It's back; limited quantity	None
Win-back	No order in 1.5 to 2× the median days between orders	3 over 2 to 3 weeks	What's new, best-sellers	Tiered: none, soft, then a real offer last
VIP	Top 5% to 10% by spend, or third order	Welcome, then monthly perks	Early access, exclusives	Access, not discounts
Sunset	No click, visit or order in 120 to 180 days	1 to 2 re-permission emails	"Still want to hear from us?"	Optional

In Omnisend's 2025 data, back-in-stock converted at 6.72% (USD 9.14 per email), welcome at 2.11% (USD 6.16) and abandoned cart at 1.72% (USD 3.59).

Edge cases. *Subscription customers* skip replenishment and win-back and get their own lifecycle: charge reminders, skip or swap prompts, and dunning. *Gift orders* (those with a gift message) get a "for yourself" cross-sell instead of replenishment. *Multi-SKU carts* trigger replenishment from the shortest-cycle item. *Discount-only buyers* get bundles or free-shipping thresholds rather than codes. *Canadian cart abandoners* can only be emailed with consent or an existing business relationship (CASL).

11.4 Campaign architecture

Element	Standard
Cadence	2 to 5 a week normally; up to daily in Black Friday week, for engaged tiers only
Segments	Engaged (clicked, visited or ordered in 30 days); warm (31 to 90 days); cool (91 to 180 days); older goes to sunset
Rotation	Engaged get every send; warm get 1 to 2 a week; cool get the strongest monthly send
Content mix	About 40% product and launches, 30% education and story, 20% social proof, 10% offers (outside peak)
Testing	One variable at a time, judged on clicks and placed orders, never opens

The best-documented case for engagement-based targeting is Patrick Ta Beauty's Black Friday 2024. The brand sent nearly six times its usual volume, but to properly segmented audiences. Its unsubscribe rate fell 37%, and email drove 30% of online revenue, up from 10% the year before (Klaviyo case study).

SMS layering. Klaviyo SMS costs about USD 0.009 to 0.012 per US text and earns mainly through automations. Use it where speed matters: abandoned checkout, back-in-stock, shipping updates and time-limited peak offers. Keep SMS campaigns to a few a month. US marketing texts need express written consent under the TCPA, and quiet hours must be respected.

11.5 Scenario: flow rebuild for a USD 6M pet brand

Illustrative. Before: a one-email welcome with 10% off, an abandoned checkout flow offering 15% in every message, no replenishment, browse or win-back flows, and four full-list campaigns a week to 70,000 profiles. Email is 11% of website revenue. **Lhotse's first 90 days:** in weeks 1 to 2, rebuild engagement tiers on clicks and orders and move 24,000 dormant profiles into sunset. In weeks 2 to 4, launch a five-email welcome series (pet-type quiz, founder story, reviews, vet-backed education, then the offer) and limit the checkout discount to the last email for first-time buyers. In weeks 4 to 8, add replenishment for the three best-selling food SKUs (45-day cycle, first reminder at day 38, subscribe-and-save offer) and browse abandonment. In weeks 8 to 12, add a 90-day win-back, a "gotcha day" flow using quiz data, and 10% holdouts on welcome and replenishment. **Measure:** email share, holdout lift, discount cost per order and the Klaviyo tier after suppression. In a food-led pet brand we would expect replenishment to become a top revenue flow within one or two reorder cycles. Proving it with a holdout is what turns a trial quarter into a long retainer.

12. Subscriber Database Hygiene, List Management & ESP Cost Control

Bottom line: Klaviyo bills on every active profile. Dormant subscribers and bot sign-ups therefore cost a brand twice, once on the invoice and again in inbox placement. Engagement tiers, a sunset flow, careful suppression and bot defences answer the most common owner complaint (a rising bill with flat revenue) and improve deliverability at the same time.

12.1 Klaviyo billing

Since 18 February 2025, Klaviyo has billed on all active profiles, and it upgrades the plan automatically when a limit is passed. Suppressed profiles leave the bill but can no longer receive email or enter flows, so suppression is a marketing decision, not just a way to save money.

Active profiles	1,000	5,000	10,000	25,000	50,000	250,000
Email price per month	USD 30	USD 100	USD 150	USD 400	USD 700	USD 2,300

SendX, a secondary source. Check Klaviyo's live prices before quoting. A USD 1M to 10M brand with 25,000 to 100,000 profiles probably pays USD 400 to 1,400+ a month for email alone (our estimate).

A TYPICAL UNMANAGED LIST: 60,000 ACTIVE PROFILES (illustrative; one block ≈ 1,500)					
Engaged (≤ 30 days)		12,000	20%	← earns most revenue	
Warm (31–90 days)		9,000	15%		
Cool (91–180 days)		6,000	10%		
Dormant (180+ days)		30,000	50%	← costs money, hurts placement	
Bots / invalid		3,000	5%	← costs money, causes bounces	

One owner described this exact pattern publicly: paying for more than 50,000 profiles while about 15,000 engaged, with flat revenue and a rising bill. Suppressing the dormant and bot segments here takes the list to about 27,000 profiles. That cuts the email bill by roughly USD 300 a month or more (our estimate), and the remaining mail goes to people who respond.

12.2 Engagement tiers and suppression rules

Tier	Definition (no opens)	Treatment
Engaged	Clicked, visited or ordered in 30 days, or joined in 30 days	Every campaign
Warm	Same signals, 31 to 90 days ago	1 to 2 campaigns a week
Cool	Same signals, 91 to 180 days ago	Strongest monthly send; targeted win-back
Dormant	Nothing in 180+ days	Sunset flow, then suppress
Protected	Ordered in 12 months, active subscriber, VIP, or open order or ticket	Never suppress automatically; keep in post-purchase and transactional mail

Suppress: hard bounces and spam complainers (Klaviyo does this automatically), sunset non-responders, confirmed bots, disposable and malformed addresses, and profiles that got 3+ emails in 180 days with no click, visit or order. That is Klaviyo's cleaning guideline with opens removed.

12.3 Sunset policy SOP

1. **Entry:** no click, visit or order in 180 days *and* no order in 12 months. Use 270 days for long buying cycles.
2. **Re-permission:** 1 to 2 emails over 7 to 10 days, with a one-click "yes, keep me".
3. **Responders** go back to the warm tier.
4. **Non-responders** are suppressed with a reason tag (such as sunset_2026Q4), so the action can be audited and reversed.
5. **Run it continuously as a flow**, not as an annual purge.
6. **Report** the profiles removed, the tier change, and the change in click and order rates.

One manufacturer who excluded unengaged profiles and added a sunset flow publicly reported opens rising from the 45% to 55% range to 65% to 70%. Opens are imperfect, but the direction holds: mailing fewer, more engaged people improves every other metric.

12.4 Bots and list bombing

List bombing is bots flooding sign-up forms with real or fake addresses. The brand then pays for junk profiles and its welcome emails bounce or hit spam traps. Warning signs: sign-up spikes at odd hours or from one country, random-string names or URLs in name fields, high bounces on welcome email 1, and clusters of obscure domains.

Controls: CAPTCHA or bot protection on every form; a hidden honeypot field; double opt-in for high-risk sources (footer forms, countries the brand doesn't ship to, API sign-ups); blocking disposable domains; alerts when daily sign-ups exceed three times the trailing average; and suppressing any affected cohort. This matches Klaviyo's own guidance. **Never buy lists.** Bought lists carry spam traps and dead addresses, and one documented case bounced 12% hard on its first send.

13. Technical Email Deliverability Engineering & Authentication Protocols

Bottom line: SPF, DKIM and an aligned DMARC record are the price of entry at Gmail, Yahoo and Microsoft, and all three now reject bulk mail that fails. DMARC at **p=none** meets every current mandate. Moving to **p=quarantine** and then **p=reject** is best practice that we carry out step by step, guided by report data. It should never be thrown at a prospect as an accusation. Every ICP brand is a bulk sender, and most have at least one sender (a helpdesk, a reviews app or a subscription tool) that is not aligned.

13.1 How authentication fits together

WHAT THE RECEIVING SERVER SEES	WHAT IT CHECKS
From: hello@brand.com	◀ visible sender DMARC: did SPF or DKIM pass AND align with this domain?
Return-Path: bounces@send.brand.com	◀ envelope sender SPF: is this IP allowed to send for send.brand.com?
DKIM-Signature: d=send.brand.com; s=selector1; ...	DKIM: does the signature verify against the key in DNS?
ALIGNMENT (relaxed): send.brand.com and brand.com share an organizational domain → aligned	

SPF checks the *envelope* sender, not the From address the customer sees. **DKIM** signs the message, and the signature usually survives forwarding. **DMARC** ties both back to the *visible* From domain through **alignment**, and tells receivers what to do with mail that fails.

13.2 SPF

```
brand.com. IN TXT "v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com include:mail.helpdesk-vendor.example ~all"
                version Google Workspace          a support tool sending as @brand.com soft-fail the rest
```

Rule	Failure it causes
One record per hostname. Two v=spf1 records make SPF invalid.	Permanent error: SPF fails for every sender
10 DNS-lookup limit. include , a , mx , ptr , exists and redirect all count, including nested includes.	Permanent error, usually triggered when an eleventh app is added
2 void-lookup limit.	Permanent error
SPF checks the Return-Path, not the From.	SPF can pass while DMARC fails on alignment
SPF breaks on forwarding.	Why DKIM alignment is the more reliable way to pass DMARC
Qualifiers. ~all is the norm, -all is stricter, +all is never acceptable.	+all authorizes the whole internet
255-character limit per TXT string.	Split long records into several quoted strings

Klaviyo's branded sending domain lives on a subdomain (for example **send.brand.com**), and its DNS records cover SPF and DKIM there. Do not add Klaviyo to the root SPF record unless Klaviyo's setup screen asks for it. Shopify's own DNS records handle SPF for Shopify-sent mail.

13.3 DKIM

The signature header names the signing domain (**d=**) and selector (**s=**). The public key sits at **<selector>._domainkey.<d-domain>** and can be queried with **dig +short TXT selector1._domainkey.send.brand.com**, or as a CNAME when the ESP delegates the key.

Standard	Requirement
Key length	2048-bit RSA where supported; 1024-bit minimum
Alignment	d= is the From domain or a subdomain of it
Coverage	<i>Every</i> tool that sends as @brand.com: Workspace or Microsoft 365, Klaviyo, helpdesk, reviews, subscriptions
Rotation	ESP-managed CNAME keys rotate automatically. Rotate self-managed keys at least yearly and after vendor or admin changes. Keep the old key published for 7+ days so rotation causes no downtime.

13.4 DMARC

A starter record at **_dmarc.brand.com**:

```
v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc-reports@brand.com; adkim=r; aspf=r
```

Tag	Meaning	Default
p / sp	Policy for the domain / its subdomains: none , quarantine , reject	Start at none
np	Policy for subdomains that don't exist (updated standard)	reject once enforced
rua	Where aggregate reports go	Always set it
adkim / aspf	Alignment mode, relaxed (r) or strict (s)	Relaxed
t	Testing flag (t=y) that replaces the retired pct tag	Use while moving to quarantine

The updated DMARC standard (2026) removed **pct**. A missing **pct=100** is not a finding. Raising it with a technical buyer tells them we are out of date.

Phase	Record	Duration	Exit criteria
0. Publish	p=none + rua	Day 0	Reports arriving
1. Discover	p=none	2 to 4 weeks	Every sending source identified as legitimate or unknown
2. Align	p=none	2 to 6 weeks	Every legitimate source passes aligned SPF or DKIM; about 98%+ of legitimate volume passes for two weeks in a row
3. Quarantine	p=quarantine (optionally t=y first)	2 to 4 weeks	No legitimate failures; no reports of missing mail
4. Reject	p=reject ; add np=reject	Ongoing	Weekly report review; every new tool added through a change request

Senders to inventory on a Shopify brand: Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, Klaviyo, Shopify notifications and Shopify Email, the helpdesk, ReCharge, the reviews and loyalty apps, invoicing, HR and recruiting tools, and 3PL notifications. The ones that break enforcement are the ones nobody remembers.

Why Shopify brands in particular. Shopify rewrites the sender to shopifyemail.com when a domain has *no* DMARC record *or two* of them. Both are visible from outside, and both are clean Ascent findings. Gaps are common even at scale. dmarcian found that among the top 500 US retail domains, 31% are at **p=reject**, 15% at **quarantine** and 28% at **none**, while 13% have no record and 13% have broken records. Only 25% of the top 100 Canadian retail domains enforce DMARC.

13.5 Mailbox provider bulk-sender mandates

Requirement	Gmail	Yahoo / AOL	Microsoft
Bulk threshold	About 5,000+ a day to personal Gmail, counted across the domain and its subdomains. Once reached, bulk status is permanent.	Bulk senders (no published number)	5,000+ a day
SPF + DKIM	Required	Required	Required
DMARC	Required; p=none is enough; must align with From	Required, and must pass	At least p=none , aligned with SPF or DKIM
One-click unsubscribe	Required for marketing mail	Required; honour within 2 days	Expected
Spam rate	Below 0.1%; never 0.3%	Below 0.3%	Low complaints expected
Enforcement	Rejects some non-compliant mail (since Nov 2025). Above 0.3%, Gmail stops mitigation until the rate stays below 0.3% for 7 straight days.	Rejects or filters	Rejects with 550 5.7.515 (since 5 May 2025)

Every ICP brand is a bulk sender. Gmail holds 54.4% of US inboxes, so one campaign to about 9,200 US profiles probably crosses Gmail's threshold (our estimate). **Rejected mail shows up as bounces** in the ESP, not in a test-inbox screenshot, so always read the bounce reasons.

13.6 Klaviyo sending setup

New Klaviyo accounts send from a shared IP and a shared Klaviyo domain, and inherit that domain's reputation. Gmail shows this as "via klaviyomail.com". Klaviyo requires bulk senders to set up a branded sending domain, and recommends one with DMARC for any account above 5,000 profiles. Its warning thresholds are stricter than Gmail's: it flags spam complaints above 0.05% (Gmail's line is 0.1%) and bounces above 2%. **Blocks on the shared pool are Klaviyo's to resolve**, and every Ascent scope must say so.

13.7 Pitch-accuracy guardrails

Not a finding	Why
"DMARC is only p=none."	p=none satisfies all three providers
"You're missing pct=100."	pct has been removed from the standard
"No BIMl is hurting delivery."	BIMl displays a logo and has no effect on placement
"Promotions tab = deliverability problem."	Gmail treats Promotions as an inbox tab
"One seed shows spam, so you're blocked."	Seeds have no engagement history

Lead instead with: no DMARC record or two records; failed alignment; the shared Klaviyo domain above 5,000 profiles; the Shopify sender rewrite; SPF over its lookup limit; missing one-click unsubscribe; transactional mail landing in spam.

13.8 Ascent zero-downtime delivery SOP

Days	Workstream	Actions	Safeguard
0	Access and baseline	Read-only Klaviyo access; DNS or IT contact; Google Postmaster Tools verification; DMARC report mailbox; metric snapshot	No DNS changes yet

Days	Workstream	Actions	Safeguard
1 to 3	Inventory and quick wins	List all senders; bring SPF under 10 lookups; remove duplicate records; publish DMARC p=none if missing	Add records before removing any; one change at a time
3 to 5	Alignment	Branded sending domain in Klaviyo; DKIM for Workspace, helpdesk, reviews and subscriptions; confirm one-click unsubscribe	Old sending path stays live until the new one verifies
5 to 10	Hygiene	Suppress bounces, bots and dormant profiles; build engagement tiers; launch sunset flow; bot protection on forms	Suppressions tagged and reversible
10 to 14	Warm-up and repair	Start the warm-up schedule (Section 14.4); fix problem providers (Microsoft first in the UK, Canada and Australia); handover document	Flows keep sending throughout
Weeks 3 to 12	Monitor and enforce	Weekly metrics; DMARC toward reject as reports allow; 30-day review; Lhotse proposal if the brand fits	Rollback plan for every DNS change

Enterprise (A3) clients usually want their own IT team to make DNS changes. For each step, give them a change request listing the exact records, why each is needed, how to verify it and how to roll it back.

14. Inbox Placement Testing, Domain Reputation & Risk Management

Bottom line: A seed test shows how a provider treats a stranger. Postmaster data shows how it treats the brand's real customers. Protect reputation by sending based on engagement, measure it with first-party signals, and reserve dedicated IPs for very large, steady senders. Average inbox rates already exceed 80%, so an 80% seed-test pass bar is a weak definition of Ascent success. Replace it with a composite scorecard.

14.1 The placement landscape

Validity's 2025 benchmark (based on 2024 seed data) found that 83.5% of marketing email reached the inbox, so about one message in six missed. Spam placement rose from 4.5% in Q1 to 8.6% in Q4.

Country	Gmail share (inbox rate)	Microsoft share (inbox rate)	Yahoo share (inbox rate)	Overall inbox
United States	54.4% (88.8%)	10.8% (75.8%)	21.8% (86.4%)	85.0%
Canada	45.5% (94.4%)	27.9% (78.9%)	12.2% (88.6%)	86.7%
United Kingdom	41.1% (91.8%)	32.3% (86.9%)	7.8% (90.2%)	87.8%
Australia	47.3% (92.6%)	30.2% (77.7%)	7.5% (86.4%)	85.0%

Validity. No data for Ireland or NZ. **Microsoft is the weak spot outside the US.** It holds about a third of mailboxes in Canada, the UK and Australia, and brands have reported months of Hotmail spam placement even when mailing only 30-day engaged profiles. For non-US brands, check Microsoft first.

Gmail's Promotions tab is not spam. Klaviyo calls it "a type of inbox", and no sender can choose which tab a message lands in. Since September 2025 Gmail has sorted Promotions by relevance, so low-engagement senders sink within the tab. The honest pitch is about visibility inside Promotions, which is an engagement and hygiene argument, not a promise to "get you out of Promotions".

14.2 The measurement stack

Tool	Shows	Limits
Google Postmaster Tools	Gmail spam rate, compliance status	Needs enough daily Gmail volume
Yahoo Sender Hub	Yahoo sender data and complaints	Yahoo only
Microsoft SNDS	IP-level Outlook data	Only useful with a dedicated IP
Klaviyo reports	Bounces, complaints, engagement by provider	Opens distorted by MPP
DMARC aggregate reports	Every source sending as the domain	Needs a processor at scale
Seed tests	Where a test lands across a panel	No engagement history; panel mix skews the score

14.3 Using seed tests properly

Seed accounts don't behave like real people, as Twilio SendGrid's guidance points out. Panel mix also moves the score: Microsoft and Apple seeds place around 75% to 76%, while Gmail and Yahoo seeds place around 86% to 87%. Weight the panel to the brand's actual mailbox mix, read results as a trend over several sends, and always pair them with Postmaster spam rates, bounce reasons and DMARC data. Real warning signs are spam placement at several providers at once, or order confirmations landing in spam.

The Ascent Health Scorecard (replacing the 80% seed bar):

Metric	Target at 30 days	Source
DMARC pass on legitimate volume	98%+	DMARC reports
Gmail spam rate	Below 0.1% (aim for below 0.05%)	Postmaster Tools
Bounce rate	Below 1%	Klaviyo
Microsoft placement	Measurably better than baseline	Weighted seed trend and provider engagement
Transactional mail	Inbox at all major providers	Seeds and real order tests
One-click unsubscribe	Present on all marketing mail	Header inspection
Revenue per recipient	Flat or better against the same weeks last year	Klaviyo

14.4 Dedicated IPs and warm-up

	Shared IP (Klaviyo default)	Dedicated IP
Reputation	Pooled with other senders	The brand's alone
Volume needed	None	High and steady; quiet spells let it go cold
Cost	Included	Extra fee plus the warm-up effort
Main risk	Pool incidents (Klaviyo's to fix)	Every mistake is the brand's alone
Best for	Nearly every brand up to about USD 20M	A3 senders with large, consistent daily volume

At Gmail, domain reputation now carries most of the weight. For almost every ICP brand, an authenticated branded domain with engagement-based sending matters far more than the IP choice. Shared pools do fail: one merchant reported a Gmail block on Klaviyo's shared IPs bouncing 22.5% and 60% of two Black Friday 2025 campaigns. Even then, the fix is usually escalating to Klaviyo and tightening targeting.

Warm-up for a new sending domain (modelled on Klaviyo's guidance; third-party "warming" tools have no role):

Weeks	Campaign audience	Flows
1 to 2	Clicked or ordered in 30 days	On
3 to 4	Engaged in 60 days	On
5 to 6	Engaged in 90 days	On
7 to 8	Engaged in 120 days	On
9 to 10	Engaged in 180 days	On

Step up only while complaints stay below 0.05% and bounces below 1%. Otherwise hold for a week. **To finish before Black Friday 2026 (27 November), warm-up had to start by about 18 September 2026. For 2027 (26 November), start by about 17 September 2027.** Brands that miss the window should stay on their current authenticated path through peak and migrate in January.

14.5 Incident runbook

Incident	Signal	Severity	First 24 hours	Recovery
Gmail spam rate > 0.3%	Postmaster Tools	Critical	Campaigns to 30-day engaged only; audit recent list sources	7 clean days, then ramp back tier by tier
Bounces > 2%	Klaviyo	High	Read bounce reasons; pause new sources; check forms for bots	Suppress the cohort; re-verify sources
Microsoft rejections (550 5.7.515)	Bounce reasons	High	Check SPF, DKIM, DMARC and alignment on that path	Fix, then retest
Shared IP blocklisted	Bounce codes; Klaviyo notice	Medium to high	Klaviyo ticket; narrow to engaged	Klaviyo moves traffic; record it in the client report
List bomb	Sign-up spike	Medium	CAPTCHA and double opt-in on affected forms	Suppress the cohort
DMARC fails after a new tool	Aggregate reports	Medium	Add DKIM or SPF for the tool	Add a change-request step
Pre-peak volume jump	Send plan	Preventive	Ramp up over 4 to 6 weeks	Peak SOP (Section 15.3)

14.6 Validity's "Heatwave" blocklist

On 3 September 2026, Validity announced Heatwave, a blocklist of domains that use synthetic warming (networks of fake accounts trading messages, opens and replies) or cold-email setups. It reported more than a million domains at launch, with Proofpoint, Spamhaus, SURBL, Comcast and beehiiv as partners. The only source so far is Validity's own announcement, and whether Gmail or Outlook use the list is unconfirmed. Specialists have separately noted that filtering of cold email has increased. **For clients**, Klaviyo's own warm-up is the right method, and nobody should use warm-up networks. **For GrowMailers**, stop all synthetic warming on its own outreach domains now (Section 17.7). A deliverability agency whose domain is on a blocklist loses its credibility.

15. Global Retail Holidays & Regional Peak Promotional Windows

Bottom line: Black Friday falls on 27 November 2026 in all six of our markets, 60 days after this document's date. The planning year runs from the early-October setup lock to the following September. Market-specific peaks such as Boxing Day, Mothering Sunday and Australia's end-of-financial-year sales shape both client

calendars and GrowMailers' selling windows. In 2025 the US peak grew while the UK, Canada and New Zealand were flat or down, so outside the US, peak revenue is about taking share rather than riding growth.

15.1 Master calendar: October 2026 to November 2027

Date	Event	Markets	Vertical relevance
6 to 7 Oct 2026	Amazon Prime Big Deal Days	All except NZ	Counter with bundles and loyalty perks, not deeper discounts
12 Oct 2026	Thanksgiving	Canada	Food and beverage, gifting
27 to 30 Oct 2026	Click Frenzy (unconfirmed; the operator was reported in liquidation)	Australia	Tentative
31 Oct 2026	Halloween	US, Canada, UK, Ireland	Confectionery; pet costumes
1 Nov 2026	UK Black Friday campaigns begin (Black Friday week is 23 to 30 Nov)	UK	Month-long UK peak
11 Nov 2026	Singles Day	All	Beauty, especially in Australia and NZ
26 Nov 2026	Thanksgiving	US	Food and beverage
27 Nov 2026	Black Friday	All six	The biggest day for all four verticals
30 Nov 2026	Cyber Monday	All six	
1 Dec 2026	Giving Tuesday	US	Cause-linked campaigns
14 Dec 2026	Green Monday	US	Last reliable ground-shipping push
19 Dec 2026	Super Saturday	US, UK	Last-minute gifting; e-gift cards
26 Dec 2026	Boxing Day (St Stephen's Day in Ireland)	Canada, UK, Ireland, Australia, NZ	Major sale day outside the US
1 Jan 2027	New Year	All six	Resolutions: supplements, wellness, food
6 Feb 2027	Lunar New Year	All	Food gifting
14 Feb 2027	Valentine's Day	All six	Beauty, food and beverage
7 Mar 2027	Mothering Sunday	UK, Ireland	Beauty and food gifting
17 Mar 2027	St Patrick's Day	Ireland and diaspora	Food and beverage
26 to 29 Mar 2027	Easter	All six	Chocolate, gifting
9 May 2027	Mother's Day	US, Canada, Australia, NZ	Beauty's biggest non-Q4 moment
June 2027	Australian EOFY sales (financial year ends 30 June)	Australia	A month-long sales period; budgets reset 1 July
20 Jun 2027	Father's Day	US, Canada, UK, Ireland	Grooming, food and beverage
July 2027 (dates TBA)	Amazon Prime Day	All except NZ	Counter-program
Late Jul to Aug 2027	Back-to-school	US, Canada	Lunchbox food, routines, supplements
5 Sep 2027	Father's Day	Australia, NZ	
26 Nov 2027	Black Friday 2027	All six	

Watch the calendar shift. Cyber Monday moves from 1 December (2025) to 30 November (2026), so November 2026 will look stronger year on year purely because of the dates, and December weaker. Warn clients before they read too much into it.

15.2 Peak size in 2025 and vertical moments

Market	Measure	2025 result
United States	Cyber Week online spend / Cyber Monday / Nov to Dec total	USD 44.2B (+7.7%) / USD 14.25B (+7.1%) / USD 257.8B (+6.8%)
Global	Shopify merchants, Black Friday weekend	USD 14.6B (+27%)
United Kingdom	Black Friday week online	-1.2%
Canada	Black Friday card volume	-4%
Ireland	Black Friday online card spend (2024)	EUR 120M (+22%)
Australia	Black Friday weekend	Parcels +6.3%; about A\$1.5B spent
New Zealand	Black Friday non-food spend	NZ\$55.6M (-6.2%)

Adobe, Shopify, IMRG, Moneris, AIB, Australia Post and a New Zealand payments company.

Concentration is the argument for Ascent. Cyber Week produced 17.1% of the US November to December season in 5 of its 61 days (our estimate from Adobe), and in one sample about one US brand in six took 30% or more of its yearly orders in Black Friday week. For those brands, a deliverability failure that week damages the whole year. Beauty and activewear were 2025's strongest peak categories in the US, UK and Australia.

Vertical	Biggest moments beyond Black Friday	Program implication
Beauty	Valentine's Day, Mothering Sunday, Mother's Day, holiday gifting, Singles Day	Gift guides, gift-with-purchase, sets
Supplements	January resolutions (the supplement "Black Friday"), September back-to-routine	Education series; subscription offers
Food and beverage	Thanksgiving, holiday hampers, Easter, Lunar New Year, summer barbecue (reversed in the southern hemisphere)	Shipping cut-offs; gifting; perishability logistics
Pet	Holiday gifting; flea and tick season (spring and summer, reversed south of the equator); adoption anniversaries	Seasonal health flows; "gotcha day" automations

Regional nuances. The UK's Black Friday runs all month, so UK segments must be live by late October. Mothering Sunday (7 March) and Mother's Day (9 May) are two months apart, so multi-market brands need two campaign tracks. Boxing Day is a major sale outside the US, and December capacity should be held for it. Australian and New Zealand summer falls over Christmas.

15.3 Peak-season email SOP

T-12 WEEKS — Authentication final; any new sending domain already warming (≈ mid-Sep)
T-10 WEEKS — List clean: sunset run, bots suppressed, engagement tiers rebuilt
T-8 WEEKS — Peak calendar drafted; offers agreed with finance (margin floor per SKU)
T-6 WEEKS — Volume ramp begins: +1 send a week to engaged and warm tiers
T-4 WEEKS — Segments, creative and flows locked; SMS consent list verified
T-2 WEEKS — QA: links, codes, one-click unsubscribe, mobile rendering, send times
PEAK WEEK — Engaged first, then wider tiers; check spam rate and bounces daily
T+1 WEEK — New buyers out of sale blasts and into post-purchase and review flows
T+3 WEEKS — Sunset peak-only sign-ups that never engage; plan January win-back

The rule that prevents most peak incidents: never let send volume jump. A list that has been quiet for months and is then blasted on Black Friday will see part of that mail land in spam. Brands that paused sending before peak have reported bounce spikes on their first sale email.

16. Go-To-Market Execution Windows & Sales Timelines

Bottom line: Pitch Lhotse when budgets reset and there is time to build: January to February, and June to mid-September. From mid-October to year-end, sell only low-risk Ascent fixes and book January starts. As of 28 September 2026, GrowMails has about three weeks of freeze-safe Ascent selling left before the Black Friday lock. The next Lhotse window opens on 4 January 2027.

16.1 The master sales calendar

Window	Dates	Lead offer	Ascent scope allowed	Lhotse	Theme
Pre-freeze sprint	Now to 16 Oct 2026	Ascent quick fixes	DMARC on the <i>current</i> domain; alignment; list cleaning; suppression; bot defences; spam triage	Book January starts only	"Protect peak without changing your setup"
Freeze	16 Oct to 31 Dec 2026	None	Emergency repairs only	Sign for January	"Let's review your peak data in January"
Best window	4 Jan to end Feb 2027	Lhotse	Full, including new sending domains	Full pitch	"New budget; here's what peak revealed"
Steady window	Mar to May 2027	Both	Full	US, Canada, non-gifting brands; Australia before EOFY	"Build the system before summer"
Second-best window	Jun to mid-Sep 2027	Both	Full; new domains warming by ~17 Sep	Aim for starts by early August	"Black Friday is won in summer"

Why this rhythm. Klaviyo's own checklist says Black Friday is won in summer, with setup, segments and flows final by early October. Agencies advise hiring email partners 8 to 12 weeks before Black Friday. Most teams freeze changes in November, and onboarding takes 2 to 3 weeks. A retainer pitched in late October is almost impossible to deliver well and very easy to lose.

```

WHERE IS TODAY RELATIVE TO BLACK FRIDAY (BF)?
├ > 12 weeks before → USD 3M-20M and in a target vertical?
│   └ YES → AUS ≥ 40 ? ASCENT NOW → LHOTSE NEXT : LHOTSE-FIRST
│   └ NO → ASCENT ONLY (USD 1-3M or USD 20M+)
├ 6-12 weeks before → ASCENT on the current domain only; Lhotse proposals dated January
├ < 6 weeks / freeze → NO NEW PROJECTS; emergency repairs; book January calls
└ January-February → LHOTSE, with Ascent work folded into onboarding if needed
  
```

16.2 Back-planning for Black Friday 2027

JUN 2027	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV
Pitch and discovery	→ Contract (latest: early August)	→ Onboarding (2-3 weeks)	→ Flows rebuilt; new domain warming by ~17 Sep	→ Setup lock (early Oct)	BF 26 Nov

For a Lhotse client to be fully peak-ready, the latest sensible signature date is early August. After that, pitch a January start instead.

16.3 Sales cycles and capacity

Offer and buyer	Typical cycle	Implication
Ascent, founder (A1)	1 to 2 weeks	Can close within the pre-freeze sprint

Offer and buyer	Typical cycle	Implication
Ascent, CRM lead + VP (A2)	2 to 3 weeks	Start by late September for October delivery
Ascent, enterprise with IT (A3)	3 to 6 weeks	Best sold in January or summer. Expect a DNS-access security review.
Lhotse, founder (L1)	2 to 4 weeks	Pitch in January, start in February
Lhotse, VP or Head of Growth (L2)	4 to 8 weeks	Start in early January for March starts
Lhotse, CMO + finance (L3)	6 to 12 weeks	Start in November or December for Q1 decisions

Planning assumptions; calibrate against GrowMailers' closed deals.

Accounts to audit per month = Target clients ÷ (reply rate × meeting rate × close rate)
 With ASSUMED rates of 10% × 50% × 25% and a target of 2 clients/month:
 $2 \div 0.0125 = 160$ audits a month ≈ 40 a week $\approx$ two researcher-days at 15–20 minutes each

Weekly rhythm: Monday, build and score about 50 accounts. Tuesday and Wednesday, run about 40 external audits and record 10 to 15 videos. Thursday, follow-ups, discovery calls and proposals. Friday, pipeline review, re-scoring, and a health check on GrowMailers' own outreach domains.

16.4 Market sequencing

Period	US	UK and Ireland	Canada	Australia and NZ
Jan to Feb	★★★★★	★★★★★ (non-gifting)	★★★★ (CASL-compliant only)	★★★★
Mar to May	★★★★	★★★	★★★★	★★★ (ready for EOFY by early May)
Jun to Aug	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★★ (new budgets from July)
Sep to mid-Oct	★★ Ascent only	★★ (UK peak starts 1 Nov)	★★	★★
Mid-Oct to Dec	Freeze	Freeze	Freeze	Freeze

17. International Marketing Compliance & Cold Outreach Law

Bottom line: Cold email to businesses is simplest in the US, which runs an opt-out regime, and in the UK when the recipient is a limited company. It is narrow in Canada and Ireland, where only published role addresses or company addresses are safe, and consent-led in Australia and New Zealand. Cold SMS is off-limits everywhere, and cold calls need screening in every market. In every country, identify GrowMailers honestly, include a postal address and a working opt-out, record where each address came from, and never buy lists.

Research, not legal advice. Confirm each country's position with a qualified lawyer before scaling outreach there.

17.1 Principles that apply everywhere

- Honest identity:** a named GrowMailers sender, the real company name and accurate headers.
- Honest subject lines** that match the content. Never put "Re:" or "Fwd:" on a first touch.
- Postal address and a working opt-out** in every commercial email.
- Fast, permanent opt-outs**, kept on one suppression list shared by every tool and teammate.

5. **Recorded provenance:** source URL and date, plus a dated screenshot for Canada, Australia and NZ.
6. **No bought lists, and no guessed or permutated addresses** in strict jurisdictions.
7. **No cold SMS, autodialed calls, AI voices or ringless voicemail** anywhere.

17.2 United States: CAN-SPAM and TCPA

CAN-SPAM covers all commercial email, including B2B, and runs on an *opt-out* basis, so prior consent is not required. Every message must still meet these rules:

Requirement	For GrowMailers outreach
Accurate headers; honest subject line	From, Reply-To and routing identify GrowMailers; the subject reflects the body
Identify the message as commercial	Say clearly that the message is about GrowMailers' services
Valid physical postal address	A street address, a registered PO box, or a registered private mailbox
Clear opt-out, honoured within 10 business days	Must work for at least 30 days after sending; no fee or login; never sell or share opted-out addresses
Vendor liability	GrowMailers stays liable if a lead-gen vendor sends on its behalf
No harvesting	Scraping addresses from sites that forbid it, or generating them by guessing, is an aggravated violation
Penalties	More than USD 50,000 per non-compliant email (adjusted for inflation each year)

TCPA governs calls and texts. Calls or texts to **mobile numbers** made with an autodialer or an artificial or prerecorded voice need prior express consent, and telemarketing needs *written* consent. **Texts count as calls**, and the FCC treats AI-generated voices as artificial. The **National Do Not Call Registry** protects residential and wireless numbers. Business landlines generally fall outside it, but founders often list a mobile as the business line, so scrub mobiles against the Registry and dial manually. Call only between **8 a.m. and 9 p.m. in the recipient's local time**, and keep an internal do-not-call list. Statutory damages are **USD 500 per violation, up to USD 1,500 if wilful**, and class actions are common. **State "mini-TCPA" laws** (Florida and Oklahoma, for example) add stricter rules.

17.3 United Kingdom: PECR and UK GDPR

- **Corporate subscribers** (Ltd, LLP, PLC, Scottish partnerships, government bodies) can receive B2B marketing email without consent, as long as GrowMailers identifies itself and offers an easy opt-out.
- **Individual subscribers**, including **sole traders** and some partnerships, need **consent**. Check Companies House first. If no company is registered, do not cold email.
- **UK GDPR still covers named business addresses** (jane@brand.co.uk is personal data). GrowMailers needs a written **legitimate interests assessment**, must tell each person where it got their data within one month (the first email's footer works), and must treat any objection as permanent.
- **A director's personal Gmail** probably counts as an individual and needs consent (our reading).
- **Calls:** screen against the **TPS** and **Corporate TPS**. Automated calls need consent.
- **Penalties:** since 5 February 2026, the maximum PECR fine is **£17.5 million or 4% of global turnover**.

17.4 Canada: CASL and the telemarketing rules

CASL is the strictest regime in our markets, and it applies to messages sent *into* Canada from anywhere, including Nepal.

- Every commercial email needs **consent** (express or implied), **sender identification** and a **working unsubscribe**.
- **Implied consent by conspicuous publication** needs **all three** of these: the person published the address (for example on the brand's site); nothing near it refuses unsolicited messages; and the message relates to their business role. The CRTC has said this gives no broad licence to email any address found online.
- **Addresses found only through enrichment tools, and personal Gmail addresses, carry no implied consent.**
- **Referral exemption:** one message is allowed after a referral from someone who has a relationship with both parties, and it must name the referrer in full.
- **Content:** sender name, mailing address, and a phone, email or web contact that stays valid for 60 days. Unsubscribes must be processed within **10 business days**.
- **The burden of proof is on the sender**, so keep a dated screenshot of where each address was published.
- **Penalties:** up to **C\$10 million per violation** for a business. Recent cases against Indeed Canada, Hudson's Bay and DavidsTea all involved broken unsubscribe processes.
- **Calls:** B2B calls are exempt from the National DNCL, but GrowMails must still **register with the DNCL operator**, keep an internal list, call only **9:00 a.m. to 9:30 p.m. on weekdays and 10:00 a.m. to 6:00 p.m. on weekends**, and identify itself. The CRTC has fined a foreign caller C\$175,000.
- **Quebec:** marketing must be available in French. Write in French or put Quebec lower in the queue.

17.5 Ireland, Australia and New Zealand

- **Ireland:** email to a **company** is allowed unless it has objected. A **named employee address** may count as an individual needing consent, so use generic company addresses until counsel confirms otherwise. **Cold calls to mobiles need consent**, and many owners list a mobile as their business number. Each unsolicited message is a separate offence, and the Data Protection Commission closed 275 direct-marketing investigations in 2025, up 88%.
- **Australia (Spam Act 2003):** consent may be express or **inferred**. Inferred consent covers conspicuously published business addresses where the message fits the recipient's role and nothing refuses such messages. Every message needs sender identification and an unsubscribe honoured within **5 working days**. Penalties for repeat breaches can reach A\$3.3 million a day. Check the Do Not Call Register before calling mobiles.
- **New Zealand (Unsolicited Electronic Messages Act 2007):** consent may be express, inferred or **deemed**. Deemed consent applies to conspicuously published business addresses, on the same terms as Australia's inferred consent. Unsubscribes must be honoured within **5 working days**.

Our research on Australia and New Zealand is incomplete. Treat both as frameworks to confirm.

17.6 Six-country comparison and pre-send checklist

Country	Cold email to brands	Safest address	Cold calls	Opt-out deadline	Risk
United States	Allowed (opt-out regime)	Named business address	Manual dial; scrub mobiles against DNC	10 business days	Low (email) / high (calls, texts)

Country	Cold email to brands	Safest address	Cold calls	Opt-out deadline	Risk
United Kingdom	Ltd, LLP, PLC yes; sole traders need consent	Named address at a verified company, with an LIA	Screen TPS and CTPS	Promptly; objection is absolute	Medium
Canada	Published addresses meeting all three tests, or referrals	Published role address	DNCL registration; calling hours	10 business days	High
Ireland	Companies yes; named staff unclear	Generic company address	No mobiles without consent	Promptly	High
Australia	Inferred consent via publication	Published role address	Check DNC Register	5 working days	Medium to high
New Zealand	Deemed consent via publication	Published role address	Check before calling	5 working days	Medium to high

Pre-send checklist:

- ☐ Real operating country confirmed (not a registered-agent address)
- ☐ Address type allowed for that country
- ☐ Provenance logged (URL, date; screenshot for Canada, Australia and NZ). UK: Companies House match and LIA on file.
- ☐ Not on the global suppression list
- ☐ Named sender; honest subject line
- ☐ Footer: GrowMailers legal name, postal address, statement that this is a message about GrowMailers' services, data-source note (UK and EU), simple opt-out
- ☐ Sequence of 3 to 4 touches over about three weeks, stopping at any reply

17.7 GrowMailers' own sending infrastructure

A deliverability agency's own outreach is its first case study. Keep cold outreach on **separate domains**, off growmailers.com. Authenticate every outreach domain fully (SPF, DKIM and aligned DMARC, moving to enforcement). **Stop all synthetic warm-up immediately** (Heatwave and SURBL listing risk, Section 14.6). Keep volume low and human: researched, personal emails at a steady per-mailbox pace. Check blocklists and Postmaster data every week, and cap bounces at 2%.

New Shopify owners are flooded with cold pitches. Community helpers often label them scams, and they single out Gmail senders and "your store has a problem" openers. The approach that works is the opposite: a specific free fix, shown in a short screen recording, with no ask. Public "free audit" offers in forums almost never get a reply.

17.8 Client-side compliance (what Lhotse must respect)

Rule	Where	Program implication
An abandoned checkout is not consent	Canada (CASL)	Email Canadian abandoners only with consent or an existing business relationship
Soft opt-in	UK (PECR)	Past customers may get marketing for similar products, with an opt-out in every message
Unsubscribe within 2 days / 5 working days	Yahoo / Australia and NZ	Never delay unsubscribes
Written consent for marketing SMS	US (TCPA)	Separate SMS consent with clear disclosure; quiet hours

Rule	Where	Program implication
French-language marketing	Quebec	French flows and campaigns for Quebec profiles
Health and supplement claims	FTC, ASA, TGA	Copy review for every health claim

18. Actionable GTM Audit SOP, Prospecting Scripts & Qualification Playbook

Bottom line: GrowMailers wins by showing, not telling. Build a precise list. Run a 15-minute non-invasive external audit. Send one specific free fix in a short personalized video. Then qualify with the prospect's own numbers. Every step below can be repeated by a researcher and will hold up in front of a technical buyer.

18.1 The pipeline

SOURCE → GATE → SCORE → AUDIT → OUTREACH → DISCOVERY → PROPOSAL → CLOSE → ONBOARD
 Store Hard LFS + 15-min Video + Their Ascent SOW Signed 30-day plan
 Leads gates AUS external email numbers → or Lhotse + holdouts
 (18.2) (5.1) (4.3) (18.3) (18.4–18.5) model (18.6) (18.8)

18.2 Step 1: Build the list

Store Leads filter	Setting
Platform and country	Shopify or Shopify Plus; US, UK, Canada, Australia, Ireland, NZ
Estimated monthly sales	USD 83k+ (Ascent). Lhotse: USD 250k+ for beauty and supplements, USD 333k+ for pet, USD 417k+ for food.
Apps to include	Klaviyo
Apps to exclude	Printful, Printify, Fourthwall; DSers, Zendrop, AutoDS, CJdropshipping
Categories	Beauty and fitness, health, food and drink, pet (apparel as secondary)
Post-filter screens	Registry trap (Section 6.5); marketplace-led; email agency hired in the last 6 months

18.3 Step 2: The non-invasive external audit (15 to 20 minutes)

Boundaries: use only public DNS and emails received as an ordinary subscriber. No login attempts, no scanning, no spoofing tests, and no contact with the brand's customers.

```
DOMAIN=brand.com
dig +short TXT $DOMAIN | grep -i "v=spf1"      # 1. SPF: expect exactly ONE record
dig +short TXT _dmarc.$DOMAIN                # 2. DMARC: expect exactly ONE v=DMARC1 record
dig +short MX $DOMAIN                        # 3. Mailbox host (Workspace, Microsoft 365...)
dig +short TXT send.$DOMAIN                  # 4. Sending subdomain (take it from Return-Path)
dig +short TXT <selector>._domainkey.<d-domain> # 5. DKIM key (s= and d= from the header)
```

Count SPF lookups by hand or with any public SPF checker (the limit is 10). Then subscribe with a Gmail and an Outlook research inbox and check the following:

Check	Where to look	A finding looks like
Sender label	Gmail sender line	"via klaviyomail.com", or a sender rewritten to shopifyemail.com

Check	Where to look	A finding looks like
Authentication	Gmail → Show original	spf, dkim or dmarc not "pass"; header . from not aligned with d=
One-click unsubscribe	List-Unsubscribe-Post header	Missing on marketing mail
Welcome delivery	Arrival time and folder	More than an hour late, or in Outlook junk
Program depth	Mail over 14 days	One-email welcome; daily blasts to a never-clicked subscriber
Forms	Signup popup	No bot protection; no double opt-in on risky sources
Browse and cart	Browse, then start checkout while identified	No follow-up within 48 hours

Finding	Severity	Offer	Plain-English phrasing
No DMARC, or two records	High	Ascent	"Your domain has no DMARC record, which Gmail and Yahoo now require from bulk senders. It's a two-minute DNS fix."
Shared Klaviyo domain above 5,000 profiles	High	Ascent	"Your emails say 'via klaviyomail.com', so your reputation is pooled with other senders."
Shopify sender rewrite	High	Ascent	"Shopify is swapping your sender for shopifyemail.com because of a DMARC gap."
Outlook junk placement	High (UK, Canada, Australia)	Ascent	"Your welcome landed in Outlook junk, and about a third of UK inboxes are Microsoft."
No one-click unsubscribe / SPF over its limit	Medium	Ascent	"Gmail requires one-click unsubscribe." / "Your SPF record exceeds its lookup limit."
Thin flows	Medium	Lhotse	"Your welcome is one email, and there's no replenishment reminder for a 30-day product."
Daily full-list blasts	Medium	Lhotse	"Sending daily to people who never click is what pushes a list toward spam."

18.4 Step 3: The 90-second audit video

Time	Beat	Script
0:00 to 0:10	Hook	"Hi {{first name}}, I'm {{name}} from GrowMailers. I joined the {{Brand}} list last week, and your {{specific email or product}} is genuinely good."
0:10 to 0:35	Finding, on screen	"One thing stood out in the headers. <i>[show it]</i> This line means {{finding}}. In plain terms: {{impact}}."
0:35 to 0:55	Why now	"With Black Friday on 27 November {{or: Gmail's bulk-sender rules}}, this is the kind of thing that turns into bounces just as volume rises."
0:55 to 1:15	Free fix	"Here's the exact fix. <i>[show it]</i> Your developer can add it in minutes, and it's in the email below."
1:15 to 1:30	Soft close	"That's it, no pitch. If you want a second pair of eyes on the rest, just reply."

Record the prospect's actual inbox or DNS output, never a generic slide, and keep it under two minutes.

18.5 Step 4: Outreach templates

Template A: Ascent, to a founder (A1 or A2)

Subject: {{Brand}}'s DMARC record

Hi {{first name}}, I joined the {{Brand}} list to study your welcome emails (the {{detail}} one is great) and noticed something in the headers: {{plain-English finding}}. Since last year, Gmail, Yahoo and Microsoft have been rejecting bulk mail that fails this check, so it's worth fixing before Black Friday volume. It's a small fix, and I recorded 90 seconds showing exactly what to change: {{video link}}. No strings attached. If you'd like me to look at the rest, just reply.

{{Name}}, GrowMailers

GrowMailers · {{postal address}} · A one-off business message about our email services. I found your address on {{source}}. Reply "no thanks" and I won't contact you again.

Template B: Lhotse, to a VP Marketing or Head of Growth (L2)

Subject: replenishment at {{Brand}}

Hi {{first name}}, I've been on the {{Brand}} list for two weeks. Your campaigns are sharp, but I didn't see a replenishment email for {{product}}, which is roughly a {{N}}-day product. At your size, a working replenishment and post-purchase system usually needs only 1% to 3% of monthly orders to be incremental to pay for a full retention team, and we prove it with holdout tests rather than platform attribution. Worth 20 minutes in January, once peak is behind you?

{{Name}}, GrowMailers · {{compliant footer}}

Template C: Enterprise Ascent, to a CRM or Retention Lead (A3)

Subject: DMARC enforcement at {{Brand}}

Hi {{first name}}, quick peer note. Your DMARC is at p=none with reporting on, which is compliant, and it looks like you're partway to enforcement. {{Sender, e.g. the reviews app}} isn't aligned yet. We run zero-downtime enforcement projects: we inventory your senders, write change requests for your IT team, and step up to reject without touching peak. Happy to share our SOP either way.

{{Name}}, GrowMailers · {{compliant footer}}

Follow-ups: on day 4, one line with a second finding. On day 10, a relevant benchmark. On day 21, close the loop ("I'll stop here. The fix in the video still stands."). Stop at any reply.

18.6 Step 5: The discovery call (30 minutes)

Minutes	Agenda
0 to 5	Their goals for the next two quarters
5 to 15	Collect the numbers and build the Section 8 model live: website revenue, AOV, gross margin, monthly orders, email share and attribution window, active profiles and Klaviyo tier, blended CPA or MER, subscription share, markets
15 to 22	Walk through the audit findings; ask what they've seen (bounces, bills, spam)
22 to 27	Fit: Ascent, Lhotse or both, with the breakeven order count
27 to 30	Next step: proposal date, who decides, start window

Qualifying questions: Who else weighs in, and how have you bought agency services before? What happened to email week by week last Black Friday? What would you expect to see in 90 days if this worked? Does DNS access need IT sign-off? **Red flags:** they demand guaranteed inbox rates, want a discount-heavy program regardless of margin, are mid-way through an ESP migration, have no clear decision maker, or show visible cash stress (Section 9.3).

18.7 Step 6: Pipeline scoring

GrowMails Opportunity Score (GOS, 0-100)

= Fit (0-40) ← LFS × 0.4 (Lhotse) or AUS × 0.4 (Ascent-only accounts)
 + Urgency (0-25) ← audit severity, recent incident, proximity to peak
 + Timing (0-15) ← inside a pitch window (Section 16.1) = 15; freeze = 0
 + Authority & access (0-20) ← decision maker engaged 20; influencer only 10; no contact 0

≥ 75 Priority: discovery within 7 days; proposal within 48 hours of the call

55-74 Active nurture: second finding or benchmark; re-score monthly

< 55 Long-term nurture or disqualify; re-score quarterly

Stage	Exit criteria
S0 Identified	Passes the hard gates
S1 Qualified	GOS calculated; lawful contact route confirmed
S2 Audited	At least one specific finding recorded
S3 Engaged	Replied or watched the video; meeting booked
S4 Discovery	Numbers collected; model built; fit confirmed
S5 Proposal	Scope and price sent; decision date agreed
S6 Closed	Won: kickoff booked. Lost: reason and re-contact date logged.

18.8 Proposals, scope and onboarding

Ascent SOW: baseline metrics, sender inventory, DNS change list with rollbacks, hygiene actions, warm-up plan, Health Scorecard targets (Section 14.3) and a 30-day review. **Lhotse proposal:** the brand's own economics, a 90-day flow and campaign plan, a holdout plan, the monthly scorecard, the scope band and fee, and a 90-day initial term. **State these exclusions explicitly:** no guaranteed inbox percentage; shared-IP blocks are Klaviyo's to resolve; ESP migrations are out of scope unless requested; DNS changes need the client's access or IT team; health claims need the client's own compliance review.

First 30 days of a new client:

- ☐ Kickoff: goals, KPIs, contacts, approvals
- ☐ Access: Klaviyo, Shopify (read), DNS or IT contact, Postmaster Tools, SMS platform
- ☐ Baseline snapshot; sender inventory; DMARC reporting live
- ☐ Engagement tiers rebuilt without opens; sunset flow live
- ☐ Top three flow fixes shipped; holdouts on the two highest-volume flows
- ☐ 60-day campaign calendar with peak moments flagged by market
- ☐ First monthly scorecard delivered

18.9 GTM engine KPIs

KPI	Cadence
Accounts audited; audit-to-reply rate; reply-to-meeting rate	Weekly
Meeting-to-close rate	Monthly
Ascent-to-Lhotse conversion within 90 days	Quarterly
Lhotse retention at 6 and 12 months	Quarterly
Holdout-tested incremental revenue across clients, divided by fees	Quarterly

KPI	Cadence
GrowMailers outreach domain health (bounces, blocklists, spam placement)	Weekly

Appendix A: Glossary

Term	Meaning
Alignment	Whether the domain authenticated by SPF or DKIM matches the visible From domain
AOV / CPA / CAC	Average order value / ad spend per purchase (new or returning) / marketing spend per <i>new</i> customer
BIMI	Standard for displaying a brand logo in the inbox; no placement effect
CASL / PECR / TCPA	Canada's anti-spam law / UK electronic marketing rules / US telephone consumer protection law
Contribution	Revenue minus product, fulfilment and payment costs
DKIM / SPF / DMARC	Cryptographic signature / list of authorized sending servers / policy tying both to the From domain
ESP	Email service provider, such as Klaviyo
Flow / campaign	Behaviour-triggered automation / one-off send
Holdout	A random group deliberately not mailed, to measure true lift
LFS / AUS / GOS	Lhotse Fit Score / Ascent Urgency Score / GrowMailers Opportunity Score
LTV / MER	Lifetime contribution per customer / total revenue ÷ total marketing spend
MPP	Apple Mail Privacy Protection, which auto-opens email
Sunset flow	Re-permission, then suppression, of long-inactive profiles
3PL	Third-party logistics (outsourced fulfilment)

Appendix B: Sources and Data Notes

Sources: US Census Bureau Quarterly E-Commerce Report (Q2 2026). Store Leads Shopify, Plus, app and Klaviyo counts by country, state and city (18 September 2026), <https://storeleads.app/reports/shopify/US/top-stores>. Klaviyo 2026 Email Benchmarks (updated 24 September 2026), <https://www.klaviyo.com/products/email-marketing/benchmarks>, plus Klaviyo's Q2 2026 results, help centre and Patrick Ta Beauty case study. Omnisend 2025 data (150,000 brands). Validity Email Deliverability 2025 Benchmark Report, <https://www.validity.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/03/2025-Benchmark-Report-FINAL.pdf>, and Validity's Heatwave announcement (3 September 2026). Google email sender guidelines FAQ, <https://support.google.com/a/answer/14229414>. Yahoo and Microsoft bulk-sender requirements. Triple Whale Ecommerce Benchmarks (21 September 2026), <https://benchmark.triplewhalelabs.com/>. Meta Q2 2026 results. ShipBob 2026 survey (416 executives). eMarketer. Litmus (July 2026). dmrcian. FIGS, Hims & Hers and Temple & Webster filings. Adobe, IMRG, Moneris, AIB and Australia Post peak results. Flypost, Level CFO, ATTN, Eightx, eCommerce Placement, Liquid Lemon and ECOM CPA guides. Glassdoor, Morgan McKinley and Indeed salary data. Regulator guidance from the FTC, FCC, ICO, CRTC, Irish Data Protection Commission, ACMA and New Zealand's Department of Internal Affairs.

Notes: (1) "Our estimate" and "planning assumption" figures are GrowMailers calculations; replace them with export or prospect data. (2) Vendor benchmarks (Triple Whale, Klaviyo, Omnisend, Validity) describe their own customers and are directional. (3) Platform attribution overstates causal impact, so holdouts are the reporting standard. (4) Legal summaries are research as of September 2026, not legal advice. (5) Community and review-site comments were used only to confirm pain points, not as statistics.